A deeper criticality assessment should consider the following dimensions:

1. Business Function Centrality
2. System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency
3. Failure Blast Radius
4. Time Criticality
5. Workaround Availability
6. Recoverability
7. Transaction Integrity Criticality
8. Data Consequence
9. Exit and Substitutability
10. Regulatory / Compliance Criticality
11. Financial Materiality
12. Concentration / Dependency Risk

V-005 BNY Deep Criticality Assessment

V-005 — BNY

Field	What we know from case	What we need to establish
Service	Real-Time Payments transmission	Exact technical architecture
Meridian process	Inbound real-time payments	Failure/recovery workflow
Dependency	High	Whether dependency is sole-provider
Data	Payment instructions, counterparty names, account identifiers	Exact data fields / sensitivity
Volume	2.1M messages/year	Approx. customers/transactions affected
Category	Payments	Regulatory obligations
AI	Unknown initially	Whether AI touches Meridian service/data

Dimension	Initial status
Business Function Centrality	**Known**
System-of-Record	**Unknown**
Blast Radius	**Partially known**
Time Criticality	**Known**
Workaround	**Unknown**
Recoverability	**Unknown**

Transaction Integrity	**Known**
Data Consequence	**Known**
Exit	**Unknown**
Regulatory	**Partially known**
Financial Materiality	**Partially known**
Concentration	**Unknown**

Dimension	Rating	Evidence status
Business Function Centrality	Critical	Confirmed
System-of-Record	High	Partially established
Failure Blast Radius	Critical	Case data
Time Criticality	Critical	Service characteristics
Workaround	Critical Candidate	Unknown
Recoverability	High	Unknown architecture
Transaction Integrity	Critical	Service/data nature
Data Consequence	Critical	Case data
Exit/Substitutability	High	Validation required
Regulatory	Critical	Financial process
Financial Materiality	Critical Potential	Monetary impact unknown
Concentration	High Potential	Additional dependencies unknown

AI Risk Assessment

High

Then:

Risk	Impact	Evidence	Gap
Data exposure	High	AI used in payment ecosystem	Meridian data flow unknown
Model error	High	AI used for anomaly detection	Model governance unknown
Provider dependency	High	External AI relationship identified	Service-specific provider unknown
Transparency	Medium/High	AI capabilities disclosed	Model-level transparency unknown

1. Business Function Centrality

Question

How central is BNY's function to Meridian's primary business operations?

Assessment

BNY provides **Real-Time Payments (RTP) transmission** for Meridian's **inbound real-time payment process**. This places BNY directly within a financial transaction workflow rather than in a peripheral or administrative business function.

The service supports the movement of inbound payment instructions into Meridian's payment-processing environment. A disruption could therefore prevent or delay the receipt and processing of real-time payments.

Unlike a vendor providing general productivity, HR, marketing, or non-critical analytical services, BNY supports a function directly connected to Meridian's financial operations.

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

BNY supports a core payment-processing function with direct relevance to Meridian's ability to receive and process real-time payments.

2. System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency

Question

Does BNY merely transmit information, or does it participate in maintaining or processing authoritative financial state?

Assessment

The provided Meridian profile identifies BNY's role as **Real-Time Payments transmission** and states that the vendor handles:

- Payment instructions
- Counterparty names
- Account identifiers

This indicates that BNY participates directly in the transmission of payment-related information.

However, the available case information does **not** establish that BNY maintains Meridian's authoritative customer master, account balances, general ledger, or complete transaction system of record.

Therefore, BNY should not automatically be classified as a system-of-record dependency in the same manner as a core banking platform.

A failure or integrity issue could nevertheless affect the accuracy, completeness, or delivery of inbound payment instructions.

BNY Rating

High

Reason

BNY is directly involved in payment processing and transmission, but the available evidence does not establish that it serves as Meridian's authoritative system of record.

Evidence Gap

Further assessment should establish:

- Whether BNY maintains authoritative transaction records
- Where the system of record for inbound RTP transactions resides
- BNY's transaction-retention responsibilities
- Settlement and reconciliation responsibilities
- Whether Meridian can independently reconstruct transactions if BNY becomes unavailable

3. Failure Blast Radius

Question

How broadly would a failure of BNY propagate across Meridian?

Assessment

The Meridian profile indicates approximately **2.1 million payment messages per year** are associated with the BNY relationship.

This represents a substantial volume of payment activity and indicates that a BNY outage would not be limited to an isolated transaction or small operational workload.

Potential areas affected include:

- Inbound real-time payment receipt
- Payment processing
- Customer receipt of funds
- Payment reconciliation
- Downstream payment-processing activities
- Operational support and exception handling

The exact number of customers or downstream systems affected by a BNY outage is not provided and should not be assumed.

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

The combination of direct payment dependency and approximately 2.1 million annual payment messages creates a potentially large transaction and operational blast radius.

4. Time Criticality

Question

How quickly does a BNY failure become materially harmful?

Assessment

BNY supports **real-time payment transmission**, making the service inherently time-sensitive.

The relevant failure progression is:

BNY Service Interruption
|
v
Inbound RTP Transmission Disruption
|
v
Delayed / Failed Payment Processing
|
v
Customer and Operational Impact
|
v
Potential Financial / Reconciliation Consequences

Real-time payment services cannot be treated in the same manner as periodic reporting or batch-processing services where an outage can simply be deferred for several days.

The available case information does not provide Meridian's formal RTO or maximum tolerable outage. Therefore, a specific recovery time should not be assumed.

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

The underlying business process is real-time payment processing, creating a low tolerance for prolonged service interruption.

5. Workaround Availability

Question

Can Meridian continue normal inbound payment operations if BNY becomes unavailable?

Assessment

A complete manual workaround for approximately 2.1 million annual payment messages would not be expected to be practical at scale.

Potential alternatives could include:

- A secondary RTP provider
- Alternate payment-rail connectivity
- Queuing and deferred processing
- Business continuity procedures
- Manual exception processing

However, the case does not establish whether Meridian currently has a secondary provider or failover arrangement.

Therefore, it would be inappropriate to conclude that Meridian has **no** workaround.

BNY Rating

Critical Candidate

Reason

Real-time payment transmission is difficult to replace manually at scale, but the existence and effectiveness of Meridian's alternate processing or failover capabilities require validation.

Evidence Gap

Further assessment should establish:

- Secondary payment provider
- Failover architecture
- Alternate payment rails
- Business continuity arrangements
- Manual fallback procedures
- Maximum tolerable outage
- RTO/RPO

6. Recoverability

Question

If BNY fails, how quickly and reliably can Meridian restore normal payment operations?

Assessment

Recovery from a BNY outage would involve more than simply restoring connectivity.

Meridian may need to establish:

- Which payment messages were successfully received
- Which messages were delayed or lost
- Whether messages require replay
- Whether duplicate transactions were introduced
- Whether transaction ordering was preserved
- Whether downstream systems received the correct information
- Whether reconciliation is complete

The recovery chain can therefore be represented as:

BNY Failure
    |
    v
Detection
    |
    v
Failover / Service Restoration
    |

v
Message Recovery / Replay
|
v
Transaction Reconciliation
|
v
Validation of Completeness and Integrity
|
v
Return to Normal Operations

The case does not provide Meridian's actual disaster-recovery architecture, RTO, RPO, or reconciliation procedures.

BNY Rating

High Consequence / Critical Dependency

Reason

Recovery may involve transaction reconstruction and reconciliation in addition to service restoration.

Evidence Gap

Meridian-specific analysis should establish:

- RTO
- RPO
- Disaster recovery design
- Failover model
- Message replay capability
- Recovery testing
- Transaction reconciliation procedures

7. Transaction Integrity Criticality

Question

What happens if payment instructions are processed incorrectly?

Assessment

Transaction integrity is particularly important because BNY directly supports the transmission of payment instructions.

Potential integrity failures include:

- Incorrect payment instructions
- Duplicate payment messages
- Missing payment messages
- Delayed payment messages
- Incorrect account identifiers
- Incorrect counterparty information
- Unauthorized modification of payment information

The potential consequence is not limited to data corruption. Incorrect payment information could result in incorrect financial transactions, customer impact, reconciliation issues, and potential financial losses.

The relevant dependency can be represented as:

Payment Instruction
    |
    v
RTP Transmission
    |
    v
Payment Processing
    |
    v
Financial Transaction
    |
    v
Reconciliation / Customer Impact

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

BNY's role directly affects the integrity and successful transmission of financial payment instructions.

8. Data Consequence

Assessment

The Meridian profile identifies the information exposed to BNY as:

- Payment instructions
- Counterparty names
- Account identifiers

These represent sensitive financial and transaction-related information.

The CIA impact can therefore be assessed as:

Data Property	BNY Assessment
Confidentiality	**High**
Integrity	**Critical**
Availability	**Critical**

Confidentiality

Unauthorized disclosure could expose sensitive payment and account-related information.

Integrity

Incorrect or altered payment instructions could result in incorrect, duplicated, redirected, or otherwise invalid transactions.

Availability

Loss of access to BNY's transmission service could prevent or delay inbound real-time payments.

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

The vendor handles sensitive payment information and directly supports the availability and integrity of financial transactions.

9. Exit and Substitutability

Question

How easily could Meridian replace BNY?

Assessment

Replacing a real-time payment transmission provider may require more than replacing a conventional SaaS application.

Potential considerations include:

- Availability of alternative RTP providers
- Payment-network connectivity
- API/interface replacement
- Integration changes
- Certification and testing
- Data migration or transaction-history portability
- Contractual termination requirements
- Operational cutover
- Reconciliation testing
- Business continuity during transition

The provided case does not establish Meridian's contractual exit terms, alternate providers, or migration strategy.

Therefore, a specific migration duration should not be assumed.

BNY Rating

High

Reason

The service is operationally important and potentially complex to replace, but Meridian's actual substitutability has not been established.

Evidence Gap

Need to determine:

- Alternative RTP providers
- Contractual exit terms
- Data portability
- Integration dependencies
- Migration strategy
- Estimated migration duration
- Cutover and testing requirements

10. Regulatory / Compliance Criticality

Question

Could BNY failure materially interfere with Meridian's regulated financial activities?

Assessment

BNY supports a payment-processing function involving real-time financial transactions.

A significant disruption or integrity failure could potentially affect:

- Payment-processing obligations
- Customer financial activity
- Transaction records
- Operational resilience
- Reconciliation
- Financial controls
- Regulatory obligations

The regulatory significance therefore arises from **the nature of the service provided to Meridian**, rather than simply from BNY being a financial-services organization.

The dependency can be represented as:

RTP Transmission
|
v
Payment Processing
|

v
Customer Financial Activity
|
v
Regulated Financial Operations
|
v
Potential Compliance / Regulatory Impact

BNY Rating

Critical

Reason

BNY directly supports a financial transaction process where prolonged disruption or transaction-integrity issues could create material compliance and operational-resilience consequences.

11. Financial Materiality

Question

Could BNY failure create material financial consequences?

Assessment

A BNY failure could create financial impact through several channels.

Operational

- Service disruption
- Incident response
- Recovery costs
- Manual remediation
- Reconciliation costs

Customer

- Delayed inbound payments
- Failed transactions

- Customer complaints
- Potential customer remediation or compensation

Financial

- Delayed settlement
- Incorrect or duplicated transactions
- Transaction losses
- Reconciliation and remediation costs
- Potential contractual costs

Regulatory

- Remediation requirements
- Potential compliance consequences

The case provides the annual message volume but does **not** provide the monetary value of transactions, Meridian's revenue exposure, contractual penalties, or estimated financial losses.

Therefore, a specific dollar impact should not be invented.

BNY Rating

Critical Potential Impact

Reason

The scale and nature of the payment dependency create potential for material financial consequences, although the exact monetary exposure requires additional evidence.

12. Concentration / Dependency Risk

Question

Could Meridian's dependence on BNY extend across multiple important functions?

Assessment

The provided case establishes BNY's role in **real-time payment transmission**.

BNY's broader business portfolio may create the potential for additional concentration if Meridian also relies on BNY for other financial services.

However, the case does not establish that Meridian uses additional BNY services.

Therefore, broader concentration should be treated as an **assessment question rather than an established fact**.

Potential additional dependencies to investigate include:

- Other payment services
- Settlement services
- Treasury services
- Cash management
- Other banking infrastructure
- Fraud or payment-validation services

BNY Rating

High Potential

Reason

BNY is already a significant payment-processing dependency, while the possibility of additional BNY dependencies could increase concentration risk.

Evidence Gap

Determine whether Meridian uses BNY for additional:

- Payment services
- Settlement services
- Treasury services
- Cash-management services
- Fraud services
- Other financial platforms

13. Deep Criticality Matrix

Criticality Dimension	BNY Assessment	Key Reason

Business-function centrality	**Critical**	Direct inbound RTP transmission
System-of-record / process authority	**High**	Direct payment processing; authoritative account state not established
Failure blast radius	**Critical**	2.1M annual payment messages
Time criticality	**Critical**	Real-time payment dependency
Workaround availability	**Critical Candidate**	Manual replacement impractical at scale; failover unknown
Recoverability	**High**	Recovery may require message recovery and reconciliation
Transaction integrity	**Critical**	Payment instructions directly affect financial transactions
Data consequence	**Critical**	Sensitive payment/account information
Exit/substitutability	**High**	Alternative provider and migration complexity unknown
Regulatory impact	**Critical**	Direct financial payment-processing dependency
Financial impact	**Critical Potential**	Potential customer, transaction and remediation consequences
Concentration potential	**High Potential**	Additional BNY dependencies require validation

14. Overall Criticality Conclusion

Recommended Criticality Tier

CRITICAL

Confidence

High

Core Reasoning

BNY's criticality is driven by the combination of:

1. **Direct involvement in inbound real-time payments**
2. **High operational dependency**
3. **Approximately 2.1 million annual payment messages**
4. **High transaction-integrity requirements**
5. **Sensitive payment and account-related information**
6. **Low tolerance for prolonged disruption**
7. **Potentially limited immediate workaround capability**
8. **Potential customer, financial and regulatory consequences**
9. **Potential recovery and reconciliation complexity**
10. **Potential substitutability and concentration concerns requiring validation**

The conclusion is therefore stronger than simply stating that BNY handles sensitive financial information.

The dependency can be represented as:

BNY RTP Transmission
|
v
Inbound Real-Time Payments
|
v
~2.1M Annual Payment Messages
|
v
High Time + Transaction Integrity Dependency
|
v
Potential Customer / Financial Impact
|
v
Potential Regulatory / Operational Impact
|
v
CRITICAL

Criticality Rationale

> **Real-time payment transmission + high operational dependency + 2.1M annual payment messages + sensitive payment information + critical**

transaction integrity + low tolerance for prolonged disruption + potentially material financial and regulatory consequences = CRITICAL.

The Clearing House Payments Company L.L.C. (V-006)

Meridian Financial | Optiv Consulting Case Study 1
Vendor Criticality and AI Security Assessment
Assessment date: 12 October 2026

1. Executive Summary

Vendor: The Clearing House Payments Company L.L.C. (TCH)
Service: ACH and Real-Time Payments (RTP) clearing and settlement infrastructure
Category: Payments Infrastructure
Business process: ACH and RTP clearing and settlement
Vendor criticality: CRITICAL
AI usage detected: YES — capability-level evidence identified; service-specific use remains unverified
AI security risk: HIGH — provisional
Assessment depth: DEEP / FULL

The Clearing House is a payment infrastructure provider supporting ACH and real-time payment services. The Meridian vendor input identifies TCH as a Critical operational dependency and records 14 million payment messages. The measurement period and the split between ACH and RTP are not specified.

TCH's role makes it important to Meridian's payment-processing operations. An outage, message-integrity failure or disruption to transaction-status handling could delay payments, create reconciliation problems and affect customers and business operations. RTP operates continuously, while ACH follows defined processing windows. These characteristics support a Critical vendor rating.

Public-source research identified AI/ML capability evidence in an official TCH Data Engineer job posting. The posting references AI and machine-learning libraries, analytics and automation. However, this does not prove that AI is deployed in Meridian's specific ACH/RTP service or that Meridian's payment messages are supplied to an AI model.

The recommended AI security risk is **High, provisionally**, because of the consequences associated with the underlying payment service and the need to validate whether AI tools access payment data or influence operational decisions. This is a precautionary assessment, not a finding of actual AI-related data exposure or a security breach.

The overall conclusion is therefore:

- **Vendor criticality: Critical**, supported by the case data and the nature of ACH/RTP clearing and settlement.
- **AI usage: Capability signal identified**, but production use in Meridian's specific service is unverified.
- **AI security risk: High, provisional**, pending validation of deployment, data flows, model providers and safeguards.

2. Vendor Profile and Assessment Scope

2.1 Case-provided information

The supplied Meridian vendor input identifies the following details:

- **Vendor ID:** V-006
- **Vendor name:** The Clearing House Payments Company L.L.C.
- **Service provided:** Payment network infrastructure for ACH and RTP clearing and settlement.
- **Category:** Payments Infrastructure.
- **Operational dependency:** Critical.
- **Data description:** Payment messages in transit only.
- **Stated volume:** 14 million messages.

These are facts supplied by the case. The 14 million figure is treated as the stated volume of the Meridian relationship, not TCH's total network volume. Its measurement period and ACH/RTP split are unknown.

2.2 Assessment scope

This assessment uses the supplied case information and publicly available sources. It evaluates vendor criticality, potential AI use, AI-related security risks and the evidence required to resolve outstanding questions.

It does not include access to Meridian's internal architecture, contracts, production logs, vendor assurance reports or private TCH documentation. No vendor contact has been made.

The assessment distinguishes between:

- **Confirmed case facts:** Information explicitly provided in the Meridian materials.
- **Confirmed public evidence:** Claims supported by official vendor or partner sources.
- **Capability signals:** Evidence that a vendor has relevant AI/ML skills, tools or technical capability, without proof of production deployment in the specific service.
- **Hypotheses:** Plausible use cases that require further evidence.
- **Unverified points:** Questions that public research could not resolve.

2.3 Initial status of criticality dimensions

The initial status indicates how much evidence is available before final ratings are assigned.

Dimension	Initial status
Business-function centrality	Known
System-of-record dependency	Partially known
Failure blast radius	Partially known
Time criticality	Known
Workaround availability	Unknown
Recoverability	Unknown
Transaction integrity	Known
Data consequence	Partially known
Exit and substitutability	Unknown
Regulatory/compliance impact	Partially known
Financial materiality	Partially known
Concentration risk	Unknown

An unknown control or dependency should trigger validation; it should not automatically be treated as proof of a weakness or as proof that adequate controls exist.

3. The Clearing House and Its Services

The Clearing House operates payment systems used by financial institutions. Its Electronic Payments Network (EPN) supports ACH processing, while its RTP network supports real-time payments.

TCH's official ACH documentation describes EPN's role in processing and distributing ACH files and supporting settlement between financial institutions. Its RTP documentation describes a network that operates around the clock and supports immediate payment clearing and settlement. [1][2]

These services have different operating characteristics:

- **ACH/EPN:** Supports batch-oriented payment processing with defined submission and settlement windows.
- **RTP:** Supports continuous, real-time payment processing, including outside conventional banking hours.

Both services are important to payment operations. An ACH disruption could delay a processing window, while an RTP disruption could prevent a payment from completing when expected. Message-integrity problems could also affect payment status, exception handling and reconciliation.

The Meridian case describes TCH's involvement as handling payment messages in transit only. This does not establish that TCH maintains Meridian's customer master records or account ledger. Nevertheless, message transmission and settlement are important stages of the payment lifecycle, and failure at these stages can have significant consequences.

4. Deep Criticality Assessment

4.1 Business Function Centrality

Question: How central is TCH's service to Meridian's business operations?

TCH supports ACH and RTP clearing and settlement, placing it directly within Meridian's payment-processing chain. This is a core financial function rather than a peripheral service such as general productivity or marketing software.

A disruption could delay or prevent payment processing through the affected rail. The exact Meridian applications and transaction routes affected have not been provided, but the business function itself is clearly important.

Rating: CRITICAL

Reason: The vendor supports payment clearing and settlement, which are central to financial operations.

4.2 System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency

Question: Does TCH maintain Meridian's authoritative customer account records, or does it process payment messages within the transaction lifecycle?

The case describes payment messages in transit only. It does not establish that TCH maintains Meridian's authoritative customer ledger, customer master or account balances.

However, TCH participates in the external payment-processing and settlement chain. RTP technical documentation defines message types and transaction-status handling, illustrating the operational importance of correct message processing. [5]

A failure could affect the acceptance, delivery, status or reconciliation of payment messages, even if the authoritative customer ledger resides elsewhere.

Rating: HIGH to CRITICAL

Reason: TCH is not established as Meridian's customer-ledger system of record, but it supports an important stage of payment processing and settlement.

Evidence gap: Confirm where authoritative transaction records reside, which network responses determine payment status, and how Meridian independently reconciles or reconstructs transactions.

4.3 Failure Blast Radius

The case records a stated volume of 14 million messages. The period covered by this figure is unspecified, so it should not be labelled annual, monthly or daily.

The service covers ACH and RTP clearing and settlement. Depending on the affected rail and transaction type, an outage could affect payment initiation or receipt, payment status handling, exception processing, reconciliation and customer support.

The exact number of customers, transaction value and downstream Meridian systems affected are not available. The assessment therefore does not assume that every TCH network or product is used by Meridian.

Rating: CRITICAL

Reason: The stated message volume and role in payment clearing and settlement indicate a potentially broad operational and transaction impact.

4.4 Time Criticality

RTP is designed for continuous, real-time payment processing. A service interruption could prevent payments from completing at the expected time. ACH processing is batch-oriented, but disruption may affect submission cut-offs, settlement windows and downstream operations. [1][2]

A possible failure sequence is:

TCH service interruption → payment messages delayed or not processed → uncertain transaction status or exceptions → customer and operational impact → reconciliation and potential financial consequences.

Meridian's formal recovery time objective (RTO), recovery point objective (RPO) and maximum tolerable outage have not been provided.

Rating: CRITICAL

Reason: RTP has continuous service expectations, while ACH has time-sensitive processing windows. Prolonged disruption is potentially material.

4.5 Workaround Availability

A complete manual replacement for payment clearing and settlement should not be assumed to be practical at the stated message volume. Payment processing relies on standardised messages, connectivity, settlement arrangements, status handling and reconciliation.

Possible mitigation options include queuing eligible ACH transactions, using alternate connectivity, routing eligible payments through another rail where permitted, and following documented procedures for delayed or uncertain payments.

These are potential options, not confirmed Meridian capabilities. ACH and RTP are not automatically interchangeable because transaction eligibility, processing time, participant reachability and settlement characteristics can differ.

Rating: CRITICAL CANDIDATE

Reason: Immediate equivalent replacement has not been established, and manual processing may not be suitable at scale.

Evidence gap: Confirm alternate rails, secondary connectivity, failover arrangements, queue/replay controls, contingency procedures and maximum tolerable outage.

4.6 Recoverability

Recovery from an outage requires more than restoring connectivity. Meridian may need to establish which messages were accepted, rejected, settled, delayed or left with an uncertain status.

A safe recovery process may require message reconciliation, duplicate prevention, exception handling and validation against Meridian's internal records. TCH's technical documentation helps explain message types and status handling, but does not establish Meridian's actual recovery architecture. [5]

The case does not provide RTO/RPO, failover topology, recovery-test results or detailed reconciliation procedures.

Rating: HIGH consequence / CRITICAL dependency

Reason: Recovery may involve resolving transaction status and reconciliation issues in addition to restoring service.

Evidence gap: Confirm disaster-recovery arrangements, recovery testing, message replay, duplicate prevention, incident escalation and reconciliation procedures.

4.7 Transaction Integrity Criticality

Payment-message integrity is essential to correct processing. Potential failure scenarios include messages that are altered, lost, duplicated, misrouted or incorrectly interpreted, as well as inaccurate transaction-status information.

Such problems could result in delayed or incorrect payments, reconciliation exceptions, customer impact and potential financial loss. These are possible consequences of an integrity failure, not claims that TCH has experienced such an incident.

TCH's RTP technical documentation and operating rules establish formal requirements for messages, statuses and network operations. They do not demonstrate that a specific control has failed. [4][5]

Rating: CRITICAL

Reason: Incorrect payment processing can directly affect financial transactions and the reliability of settlement records.

4.8 Data Consequence

The case describes the information as payment messages in transit only. This is narrower than a relationship involving full customer master records or a core account ledger, but payment messages may still contain sensitive financial or personal information.

Potential data elements depend on the message type and configuration and may include names, account or routing identifiers, transaction amounts, payment references and remittance information. The exact fields available to TCH under Meridian's arrangement have not been confirmed.

The potential confidentiality, integrity and availability consequences are:

- **Confidentiality — High:** Unauthorised disclosure of payment-message content or metadata could expose sensitive information.

- **Integrity — Critical:** Altered, duplicated, missing or incorrectly processed messages could affect payment execution and reconciliation.
- **Availability — Critical:** Loss of access to a payment rail could prevent or delay processing.
- **Retention and secondary use — Unverified:** Public evidence does not establish the fields retained for Meridian, retention periods or secondary use.

TCH offers a Token Service intended to reduce exposure of underlying payment-account information in supported flows. This is a data-protection capability, but there is no confirmation that Meridian uses it or that all relevant fields are tokenised. [7]

Rating: CRITICAL overall

Reason: The principal concern is the consequence of compromising payment processing and message integrity, while the exact data fields and retention arrangements remain to be validated.

4.9 Exit and Substitutability

Replacing a payment-network service may require new connectivity, interface changes, operational testing, settlement arrangements, reconciliation updates and coordination with counterparties.

The existence of other payment rails does not prove that Meridian can substitute them immediately. ACH and RTP have different processing characteristics, and not every payment is eligible for every rail.

The case does not provide contractual exit terms, alternative-provider arrangements, portability rights or a migration plan.

Rating: HIGH

Reason: Replacing the service may involve significant technical and operational work, but the actual difficulty and duration have not been established.

Evidence gap: Confirm termination provisions, alternative-provider eligibility, migration requirements, testing and cutover plans.

4.10 Regulatory and Compliance Criticality

ACH and RTP operate within a financial ecosystem governed by operating rules and participant obligations. TCH publishes operating rules, technical documentation and RTP participant self-audit information. Its public materials describe formal responsibilities around network participation and compliance. [4][6]

A major disruption or integrity failure could affect payment-processing obligations, transaction traceability, fraud handling, reconciliation and operational resilience.

The precise obligations applicable to Meridian depend on its role, contractual arrangements and relevant regulatory requirements. The public sources reviewed do not establish Meridian's full legal or regulatory position.

Rating: CRITICAL

Reason: The vendor supports a core financial process with formal network obligations and potential operational and compliance consequences.

4.11 Financial Materiality

A material TCH outage or integrity incident could create costs through delayed or failed payments, incident response, customer support, reconciliation, remediation and potential contractual consequences. Depending on the affected transactions, it could also disrupt liquidity and treasury operations.

The case does not provide transaction values, revenue exposure, contractual penalties or a quantified loss scenario. The 14 million-message figure alone is not enough to calculate the monetary value at risk.

Rating: CRITICAL POTENTIAL IMPACT

Reason: Payment clearing and settlement failures could have material financial consequences, although the amount of potential loss remains unquantified.

4.12 Concentration and Dependency Risk

The case confirms Meridian's ACH and RTP relationship with TCH. TCH operates other payment-related services, but the case does not establish that Meridian uses every TCH product or that the services share a common failure domain.

Concentration risk could increase if Meridian depends on multiple TCH services, common connectivity, shared operational teams or common third-party technology. These possibilities require validation.

Rating: HIGH POTENTIAL

Reason: TCH is already a significant payment-infrastructure dependency, but additional Meridian dependencies and shared failure domains are unconfirmed.

Evidence gap: Map all TCH services used by Meridian, relevant technology providers, shared connections and the independence of any alternative payment arrangements.

5. Criticality Matrix and Final Decision

The ratings below summarise the assessment. They reflect the consequences of service failure as well as the evidence available; they do not imply that every possible weakness has been confirmed.

Dimension	Assessment	Main reason
Business-function centrality	Critical	ACH/RTP clearing and settlement
System-of-record/process authority	High to Critical	Payment processing is established; Meridian's ledger location is not
Failure blast radius	Critical	Stated 14 million-message volume; period unknown
Time criticality	Critical	Continuous RTP and time-sensitive ACH processing
Workaround availability	Critical candidate	Equivalent failover is unverified
Recoverability	High consequence	Message-status recovery and reconciliation may be required
Transaction integrity	Critical	Message errors can affect financial transactions
Data consequence	Critical overall	Payment integrity and availability are highly consequential
Exit/substitutability	High	Alternative arrangements and migration effort are unknown
Regulatory/compliance	Critical	Core payment process and network obligations
Financial materiality	Critical potential impact	Potential payment, liquidity and remediation consequences

Concentration risk	High potential	Additional dependencies and shared failure domains are unknown

Overall criticality decision

Recommended tier: CRITICAL
Confidence: Very high

The rating is supported by the Critical dependency recorded in the case, TCH's role in ACH/RTP clearing and settlement, the stated message volume and the potentially serious consequences of payment-processing disruption.

The decision does not depend on assuming that TCH stores Meridian's full customer ledger. Even with the narrower description of payment messages in transit only, the vendor supports a financially important process where availability and message integrity are critical.

Criticality rationale: Core payment clearing and settlement + stated Critical dependency + 14 million messages + real-time RTP expectations + high integrity and availability consequences + potentially difficult immediate substitution = **CRITICAL**.

6. Methodology and Evidence Gaps

6.1 Assessment approach

A single additive score may understate a vendor whose failure could interrupt a core financial function. This assessment therefore considers both the individual dimensions and the overall consequences of a service failure.

The criticality override is appropriate when a vendor is directly involved in payment clearing or settlement and a material outage could disrupt core payment operations without a demonstrated equivalent workaround.

V-006 meets the threshold for a Critical assessment because the case explicitly identifies a Critical dependency and ACH/RTP clearing and settlement as the supported business process.

6.2 Key evidence gaps

The following information should be established before treating this OSINT assessment as a complete production third-party risk review:

1. The period covered by the 14 million-message figure and the ACH/RTP split.
2. The exact message fields transmitted, processed, logged or retained.
3. Whether Meridian connects directly to TCH or through an intermediary.

4. The TCH systems and third parties involved in Meridian's service.
5. Whether any production AI/ML component supports EPN/RTP, fraud controls, operational analytics or support workflows.
6. Whether Meridian payment data, logs or metadata are sent to AI models or AI-enabled tools.
7. The identities, locations and data-handling terms of relevant AI providers and sub-processors.
8. Whether AI outputs can influence payment acceptance, rejection, routing, fraud escalation or other consequential operations.
9. Human oversight, model validation, audit logging, change control, override and disablement arrangements, if AI is used.
10. Meridian's RTO/RPO, failover arrangements, recovery testing, message replay and reconciliation procedures.
11. Contractual service levels, incident notification, audit rights, data retention and exit arrangements.
12. Whether Meridian uses additional TCH services or shares common technology dependencies.

These are unresolved questions, not findings of non-compliance or proof that controls are absent.

7. AI Usage Assessment

7.1 Overall finding

AI usage detected: YES — capability/engineering level.
AI use in Meridian's specific ACH/RTP service: UNVERIFIED.

The strongest direct AI-related evidence is an official TCH Data Engineer job posting that refers to AI/ML libraries, analytical models, analytics and automation. It also mentions Amazon SageMaker as a relevant machine-learning tool. This is a credible capability signal, but a job posting does not prove that an AI model operates in the production EPN/RTP path or receives Meridian's payment messages. [3]

A TCH annual conference recap also discusses AI in cybersecurity in the context of security leadership and the financial-services environment. This is supporting context, not proof that TCH operates a particular AI security product. [9]

TCH's public fraud-control materials, RTP operating rules and Token Service provide evidence of payment-risk controls and data-protection capabilities. However, fraud alerts, network monitoring and tokenisation should not be labelled AI unless a source explicitly establishes that AI/ML is used in the specific capability. [4][7]

7.2 Confirmed evidence versus hypotheses

Supported by reviewed sources:

- TCH's engineering/analytics role profile references AI/ML libraries, analytics and automation.
- TCH publicly discusses AI in cybersecurity.
- TCH publishes RTP operating rules and fraud-control requirements.
- TCH offers a Token Service for supported payment flows.
- Mastercard is identified as a technology partner for the RTP network.

Hypotheses requiring validation:

- AI/ML may support operational analytics, anomaly detection or capacity analysis.
- AI/ML may support fraud-risk analysis or cybersecurity alert triage.
- Analytics tools may process payment-related operational metadata.
- AI-assisted tools may be used in internal support or engineering workflows.

The hypotheses are plausible areas to investigate, not confirmed TCH production deployments.

The reviewed public sources do not establish that AI accepts, rejects, routes or settles Meridian payments. They also do not establish that Meridian's payment-message content is submitted to an external large language model or other AI service.

7.3 Evidence strength

The official TCH Data Engineer posting is the strongest direct AI-related signal because it names AI/ML libraries and related technical work. Its limitation is that it establishes capability rather than deployment in the contracted service.

The conference recap provides context about AI and cybersecurity but does not identify a deployed product. The RTP operating rules and technical documentation are strong sources for understanding payment operations, but they are not direct evidence of AI use.

This distinction is important: a vendor can have AI capability without using it in every product or processing every customer's data through a model.

8. Evidence Register

Research date: 12 October 2026

The following sources support the assessment. Evidence strength refers to how directly the source supports the particular finding, not to an overall guarantee of vendor security.

E-01 — TCH ACH service page

Source: Official product documentation
URL: https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/ach
Classification: Confirmed primary source — high evidence.

The page describes EPN's ACH processing role and its importance within U.S. commercial ACH activity. It supports the assessment of business-function centrality and payment-network impact. It does not directly establish AI use.

E-02 — TCH RTP network page

Source: Official product documentation
URL: https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/rtp
Classification: Confirmed primary source — high evidence.

The page describes RTP as a real-time payment network operating around the clock. It supports the time-criticality and availability assessment. It does not directly establish AI use.

E-03 — TCH Data Engineer job posting

Source: Official recruitment page
URL:
https://theclearinghouse.wd108.myworkdayjobs.com/en-US/TheClearingHouse/job/Data-Engineer_JR100049
Classification: AI capability signal — medium-high evidence.

The posting references AI/ML libraries, analytical models, scalable data platforms and automation. It supports the conclusion that AI/ML capability is present or sought within TCH's engineering/analytics work. It does not prove production use in Meridian's EPN/RTP service or access to Meridian data.

E-04 — TCH 2025 Annual Conference Recap

Source: Official vendor event recap
URL:
https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/Articles/2025/11/2025-Annual-Conference-Recap
Classification: Supporting context — medium evidence.

The recap discusses AI in cybersecurity in the financial-services environment. It does not confirm a specific TCH AI security product or an AI component in Meridian's payment path.

E-05 — TCH RTP Operating Rules

Source: Official operating rules
URL:

https://www.theclearinghouse.org/-/media/New/TCH/Documents/Payment-Systems/RTP_Operating_Rules_June-16-2025.pdf
Classification: Confirmed primary source — high evidence.

The rules describe participant responsibilities and fraud-related obligations. They support the importance of payment-network governance and operational controls. They do not establish that fraud alerts use AI/ML.

E-06 — TCH RTP Technical Documentation

Source: Official technical documentation
URL: https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/rtp/technical-documentation
Classification: Confirmed primary source — high evidence.

The documentation defines message types and payment-status handling. It supports the importance of correct message processing and reconciliation, but makes no direct AI claim.

E-07 — TCH Token Service

Source: Official product announcement
URL: https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/Articles/2025/10/Token-Service
Classification: Confirmed product — high evidence.

The announcement describes a tokenisation capability for supported payment flows. This may reduce exposure of underlying account information, but does not establish that Meridian uses the service or that it uses AI.

E-08 — Mastercard and TCH RTP partnership

Source: Official partner announcement
URL:
https://newsroom.mastercard.com/news/press/2024/january/mastercard-and-the-clearing-house-extend-partnership-on-real-time-payments/
Classification: Confirmed technology partnership — high evidence.

The announcement identifies Mastercard as a technology partner for RTP. It supports the need to map third-party technology dependencies, but does not establish that Mastercard is an AI model provider or processes Meridian data through AI.

E-09 — TCH RTP participant self-audit

Source: Official compliance resource
URL: https://www.theclearinghouse.org/payment-systems/rtp/self-audit
Classification: Confirmed primary source — high evidence.

The page describes participant self-audit obligations under the RTP framework. It supports the governance and compliance assessment but should not be treated as a complete description of TCH's own assurance programme.

E-10 — Mastercard TCH case study

Source: Official technology partner case study
URL:
https://www.mastercard.com/global/en/news-and-trends/Insights/2026/the-clearing-house-case-study.html
Classification: Supporting context — medium-high evidence.

The case study describes the TCH–Mastercard RTP relationship and its role in real-time payments. It supports understanding of the technology partnership, but does not prove AI use in Meridian's specific service.

Evidence conclusion

The reviewed public sources support TCH's payment-infrastructure role and provide an AI/ML capability signal. They do not establish service-specific AI deployment, Meridian-to-model data flows or a confirmed AI model provider for Meridian's arrangement.

9. How TCH May Be Using AI

The following are potential use cases, ordered by their relevance to the evidence. Only the engineering/analytics capability signal is directly supported by the AI-related job posting.

9.1 Analytics and data-platform engineering

Classification: Capability signal — medium-high confidence.

The Data Engineer posting references analytics, analytical/statistical models, automation and AI/ML libraries. This supports the conclusion that TCH has or is seeking relevant technical capability. [3]

If analytical platforms process payment-related operational data, that data could potentially include volumes, processing times, exceptions or service-performance metadata. The reviewed sources do not show that Meridian's messages are supplied to such tools.

9.2 Operational analytics

Classification: Hypothesis — requires validation.

AI/ML could potentially help identify unusual processing patterns, forecast capacity needs or analyse service-performance trends. The job posting's analytics and automation language makes this a reasonable area to investigate, but it does not confirm production deployment.

If used, risks could include false alerts, missed anomalies, unclear model reasoning or inappropriate access to operational data. These are possible risk scenarios, not findings of incidents at TCH.

9.3 Fraud and risk analytics

Classification: Potential use case — unconfirmed.

TCH publishes RTP fraud-control and operating-rule materials. AI/ML could potentially support anomaly detection or fraud-risk analysis, but the reviewed sources do not prove that TCH's specific fraud controls use AI. [4]

A fraud-control requirement is not automatically an AI control, and a network alert is not automatically an AI-generated alert. A bank participant's own fraud model should also not be confused with a TCH-operated model.

9.4 Cybersecurity monitoring

Classification: Supporting context / potential use case.

TCH's conference recap discusses AI in cybersecurity. Possible applications in the sector include alert analysis, anomaly detection and investigation support, but the reviewed article does not confirm deployment of a specific TCH AI security product. [9]

The key question for Meridian is whether any such tools can access payment-message content or only infrastructure telemetry.

9.5 AI in the production payment path

Classification: Unverified — high-priority question.

No reviewed public source confirms that AI/ML accepts, rejects, routes, settles or otherwise makes consequential decisions on Meridian's ACH/RTP messages. There is also no confirmed evidence that Meridian's message content is supplied to an external AI model.

This remains the central AI evidence gap and should not be filled by inference from the job posting.

10. Named AI Providers, Technology Partners and Sub-processors

10.1 Mastercard

Mastercard is identified as a technology partner for TCH's RTP network. This is a confirmed technology relationship and is relevant to third-party dependency mapping. [8]

However, the reviewed partnership announcement does not establish that Mastercard provides AI models for Meridian's service or that Mastercard AI systems receive Meridian payment data.

Classification: Confirmed technology partner; AI sub-processor status unverified.

10.2 Amazon SageMaker and other AI model providers

The TCH Data Engineer posting references Amazon SageMaker as a relevant machine-learning tool. This is a capability reference, not proof that SageMaker is used in production for Meridian's service or that Amazon receives Meridian payment messages. [3]

Finding: No AI model provider or AI sub-processor was confirmed for Meridian's specific TCH ACH/RTP service in the reviewed public sources.

10.3 Other possible service providers

A full assessment should identify any connectivity, hosting, software, managed-service, logging, observability or support providers that can access Meridian-related data.

These are categories to investigate, not claims that each provider is involved. Provider identities, processing locations, retention, model-training use and contractual protections remain unverified.

11. AI Security Risk Classification and Rationale

Classification: HIGH — provisional.

Risk tags: Critical payment dependency; sensitive payment data; AI/ML capability signal; service-specific AI use unverified; data flow unverified.

TCH supports a Critical payment-infrastructure dependency, and the case identifies payment messages in transit with a stated volume of 14 million messages. Public evidence identifies AI/ML capability within TCH's engineering and analytics environment. This creates a reasonable need to determine whether AI tools access payment data, operational metadata or support information.

However, the reviewed sources do not establish that AI is deployed in Meridian's specific ACH/RTP service, that Meridian messages are supplied to a model or that AI outputs control payment decisions.

The High rating is therefore a precautionary risk-prioritisation judgment based on the criticality of the service and the credible AI/ML capability signal. It is **not a finding of actual AI-related exposure, a breach or a confirmed control failure**.

11.1 Main risk scenarios

Payment-data exposure — high potential impact, unverified.
If Meridian payment messages or sensitive metadata are supplied to an external model, retention, processing location, access control and model-training use become important concerns. No such data flow has been confirmed.

Model error affecting operations — high potential impact, unverified.
If an AI component influences payment handling, inaccurate outputs could cause delays, unnecessary investigations or missed anomalies. There is no evidence that AI outputs currently control Meridian's payment path.

External provider dependency — potential risk, provider unconfirmed.
An AI model or managed service could introduce additional dependencies and data-handling obligations. Mastercard's technology partnership and the SageMaker reference do not, by themselves, confirm an AI sub-processor relationship.

Transparency and governance — unverified.
The reviewed sources do not provide service-specific model documentation, decision authority, validation evidence or human-oversight arrangements for Meridian's service. This does not prove such controls are absent.

11.2 Why High rather than Low?

A Low AI-specific rating would be premature while a credible AI/ML capability signal exists and service-specific data flows remain unknown. The consequences of the underlying payment dependency justify targeted validation.

11.3 Why not automatically Critical for AI security?

Critical vendor status does not automatically make the AI-specific risk Critical. The evidence reviewed does not establish that Meridian data is sent to AI models or that AI can make or execute consequential payment decisions.

The AI security rating should be escalated to Critical if evidence confirms sensitive Meridian data is exposed to external AI models without adequate safeguards, or that AI components can materially control payment decisions without strong, validated controls.

Vendor criticality and AI security risk are separate judgments. TCH can remain a Critical vendor even if AI-specific exposure is later ruled out.

12. Recommended Actions

Priority 1 — Validate service-specific AI deployment

Establish whether production AI/ML supports Meridian's EPN/RTP service, including fraud controls, operational analytics, incident triage, support tooling or message processing.

Use approved internal vendor-management processes to obtain service-specific architecture, an AI inventory and relevant technical documentation. Corporate AI capability or a job posting should not be treated as proof of production use in Meridian's payment path.

Priority 2 — Map payment-message data flows

Document the message types and fields transmitted, processed, logged, retained or made available to TCH and its service providers.

Determine whether any AI component can access raw message content, pseudonymised information, metadata, diagnostic logs or only aggregated operational metrics.

Priority 3 — Identify AI providers and sub-processors

If AI is used, identify each model or managed AI service, the provider, processing location, retention period, model-training policy, tenant isolation, encryption, access controls and contractual protections.

Do not classify Mastercard, AWS or another technology provider as an AI sub-processor without service-specific evidence.

Priority 4 — Validate AI safeguards and decision authority

If AI/ML is used, determine whether its outputs are advisory or can trigger consequential actions.

Review human oversight, output validation, false-positive and false-negative monitoring, audit logging, model/version traceability, change control, override procedures and safe disablement. AI that influences payment processing requires stronger assurance than an internal analytics tool with no operational authority.

Priority 5 — Validate payment resilience and recovery

Assess ACH and RTP separately. Confirm RTO/RPO, incident escalation, connectivity redundancy, failover, queue/replay controls, duplicate prevention, settlement reconciliation, alternate-rail feasibility and recovery-test evidence.

Do not assume ACH and RTP are interchangeable without validating transaction eligibility, timing and business requirements.

Priority 6 — Review contractual and compliance controls

Review service-level commitments, incident notification, audit rights, subcontractor disclosure, data retention/deletion, business continuity and exit assistance.

Confirm which obligations apply to TCH, Meridian and any intermediary rather than assuming that participant-facing network rules cover every contractual or regulatory requirement.

Priority 7 — Maintain evidence and reassess risk

Maintain an evidence register containing source URLs, retrieval dates, evidence classifications, confidence levels, limitations and unresolved questions.

Reassess the AI security rating when service-specific deployment and data-flow evidence becomes available. Consider escalation if sensitive Meridian data is exposed to external models without adequate safeguards, AI materially controls payment decisions without validated controls, or an undisclosed AI dependency creates a material security concern.

A lower AI-specific rating may be considered if evidence demonstrates that AI does not process Meridian data or influence the contracted service. This would not change the underlying Critical vendor rating.

13. Final Decision

The Clearing House Payments Company L.L.C. (V-006): CRITICAL vendor dependency.

AI security risk: HIGH, provisional pending service-specific validation.

Assessment depth: DEEP / FULL.

The Critical rating is supported by TCH's role in ACH and RTP clearing and settlement, the case's stated Critical dependency, the 14 million-message volume and the potentially serious consequences of payment availability or integrity failures.

The AI finding is more limited. Public evidence supports AI/ML capability within TCH's engineering and analytics environment, but does not confirm AI deployment in Meridian's specific payment-processing path, AI access to Meridian's messages or a named AI sub-processor for the service.

The appropriate next step is targeted validation of production AI use, data flows, providers, decision authority and safeguards—not an unsupported assertion that AI-related exposure has already occurred.

References

1. The Clearing House, ACH Services / EPN Network.
2. The Clearing House, Real Time Payments Network.
3. The Clearing House, Data Engineer job posting, JR100049.
4. The Clearing House, RTP Operating Rules.
5. The Clearing House, RTP Technical Documentation.
6. The Clearing House, RTP Participant Self-Audit.
7. The Clearing House, Token Service.
8. Mastercard, Mastercard and The Clearing House extend partnership on real-time payments.
9. The Clearing House, 2025 Annual Conference Recap.
10. Mastercard, The Clearing House case study.

V-004 Terrapin Technologies — Deep Criticality Assessment

Case Study 01 · Vendor AI Usage Analysis · Meridian Financial

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V-004 — Terrapin Technologies, Inc.

Field	What we know from case	What we need to establish
Service	Wealth management data solution consolidating data from multiple sources; supports commission calculations, accounting activities and business volume tracking	Exact architecture, integration method and data feeds
Meridian process	Wealth management reporting and advisor compensation	Downstream consumers of outputs (payroll, client statements, regulatory reporting)
Dependency	Moderate	Whether Terrapin is sole-provider and sole source of truth for advisor compensation
Data	Portfolio holdings, revenue and advisor compensation data	Exact fields, whether client identifiers or tax IDs are included

Volume	38,000 wealth clients; 12 monthly cycles	Number of advisors, payout values per cycle
Category	Data and Reporting	Regulatory obligations attached to reporting and compensation
AI	Unknown initially	Whether AI touches Meridian service or data

Initial status by dimension

Dimension	Initial status
Business Function Centrality	Known
System-of-Record	Partially known
Blast Radius	Partially known
Time Criticality	Known (monthly cycle)
Workaround	Unknown
Recoverability	Unknown
Transaction Integrity	Partially known

Data Consequence	Known
Exit	Unknown
Regulatory	Partially known
Financial Materiality	Partially known
Concentration	Unknown

Rating and evidence status

Dimension	Rating	Evidence status
Business Function Centrality	High	Case data
System-of-Record	High	Partially established
Failure Blast Radius	High	Case data
Time Criticality	Medium	Service characteristics (12 monthly cycles)
Workaround	Medium	Unknown, validation required
Recoverability	Medium	Unknown architecture

Transaction Integrity	High	Service/data nature
Data Consequence	High	Case data
Exit/Substitutability	Medium	Validation required
Regulatory	High	Partially established
Financial Materiality	High Potential	Monetary impact unknown
Concentration	Medium Potential	Additional dependencies unknown

AI Risk Assessment (provisional)

Medium — pending first-pass OSINT confirmation

Risk	Impact	Evidence	Gap
Data exposure	High if AI confirmed	Vendor aggregates holdings, revenue and compensation data	Whether any of it reaches AI models is unknown
Model error	Medium/High if AI confirmed	AI in commission calculation or data-cleansing would affect advisor pay	No evidence AI is used in calculations
Provider dependency	Unknown	No AI provider named in sources reviewed	Sub-processor list not yet reviewed

Transparency	Medium	Public listing describes "automation" and "analytics" only	Automation is not proof of AI; needs corroboration

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1. Business Function Centrality

Question: How central is Terrapin's function to Meridian's primary business operations?

Assessment: Terrapin consolidates data from multiple sources and supports commission calculations, accounting activities and business volume tracking for Meridian's wealth management business. It sits inside an important back-office function: it shapes how advisors are paid and how wealth business is measured and reported.

It is more important than a vendor providing HR software, marketing services or general productivity tools. It is less central than a core banking or payment-rail provider: it does not process customer accounts or move customer money, and the wealth segment is one business line rather than Meridian's entire franchise.

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: Terrapin supports an important revenue-measurement and advisor-compensation process, but not Meridian's primary account-processing or payment-execution function.

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2. System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency

Question: Does Terrapin merely receive Meridian information, or does it maintain authoritative state for a business process?

Assessment: The case states that Terrapin handles portfolio holdings, revenue and advisor compensation data, and consolidates data from multiple sources. It likely holds the authoritative calculation of advisor commissions and the consolidated reporting view of wealth business volume.

However, the underlying source data (custody, trading and account records) is expected to originate in other systems. Terrapin should therefore not be treated as the system of record for client holdings or balances.

Source systems (custodians, core, trading)
|

v
Terrapin aggregation and cleansing
|
v
Commission / compensation calculation
|
v
Advisor payout inputs, reporting, accounting entries

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: Terrapin is the likely process authority for advisor compensation calculation, but is not shown to be the authoritative record for client accounts.

Evidence Gap:

- Whether Terrapin output feeds payroll or payout directly or is reviewed before release
- Whether Meridian retains the source data to recompute commissions independently
- Where the authoritative compensation plan rules are maintained

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3. Failure Blast Radius

Question: How broadly would a failure propagate?

Customer blast radius: 38,000 wealth clients are in scope. This is a defined segment, not the whole customer base, and impact is mainly to reporting accuracy rather than access to funds.

Data blast radius: Portfolio holdings, revenue and advisor compensation data. This spans client financial information and employee-sensitive pay information.

Process blast radius: 12 monthly cycles per year. A failure in a cycle can affect advisor compensation, accounting entries and business-volume reporting for the whole period.

Terrapin platform
|
+--> Advisor commission calculation
|
+--> Accounting activity inputs
|
+--> Business volume tracking
|
+--> Wealth reporting / analytics

The exact downstream Meridian systems and the number of advisors affected are not provided and should not be assumed.

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: A defined but substantial client population and a full compensation cycle are exposed, with limited direct customer-transaction impact.

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4. Time Criticality

Question: How quickly does a Terrapin failure become materially harmful?

Assessment: The case describes 12 monthly cycles, which indicates a periodic, batch-oriented process rather than 24/7 real-time processing. An outage of hours is unlikely to cause material harm; harm builds toward month-end close, advisor payout deadlines and regulatory or client reporting dates.

Service interruption
    |
    v
Monthly cycle delayed or incomplete
    |
    v
Commission payout / accounting close at risk
    |
    v
Advisor and reporting consequences

The case does not provide Meridian's RTO or payout calendar, so a specific recovery time should not be assumed.

Terrapin Rating: Medium

Reason: The process is periodic and tolerates short interruption, but becomes time-sensitive around cycle deadlines.

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5. Workaround Availability

Question: Can Meridian continue operating if Terrapin becomes unavailable?

Manual workaround: Recalculating commissions for a full advisor population manually is laborious and error-prone, but a monthly cycle allows days rather than minutes to respond.

Alternate platform: No alternative provider is identified in the case material.

Deferred processing: Delaying a cycle is plausible; the tolerance for delay depends on payout and close deadlines.

Terrapin Rating: Medium

Reason: A degraded manual or deferred workaround appears feasible given the monthly cadence, but its effectiveness is unvalidated.

Evidence Gap:

- Documented manual calculation procedure
- Retention of raw source data in Meridian systems
- Maximum tolerable delay for advisor payouts
- Prior-period outputs available for fallback

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6. Recoverability

Question: If Terrapin fails, how quickly and reliably can Meridian restore normal operations?

Failure
  |
  v
Detection
  |
  v
Service restoration
  |
  v
Re-ingestion / rerun of source data
  |
  v
Commission and reporting reconciliation
  |
  v
Return to normal cycle

Because the process is batch-based, recovery can mostly be a rerun from source data rather than replay of in-flight transactions. The main complexity is validating that rerun results match expected figures and that no payouts were issued on corrupted calculations.

Terrapin Rating: Medium

Reason: Batch rerun is feasible, but reconciliation of compensation figures adds effort and risk.

Evidence Gap: RTO/RPO, disaster recovery design, backup and restore testing, reconciliation procedure, retention of prior-cycle snapshots.

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7. Transaction Integrity Criticality

Question: What happens if Terrapin calculations or consolidated data are wrong?

- **Confidentiality:** exposure of client holdings and advisor pay
- **Availability:** a cycle cannot be completed on time
- **Integrity:** commissions, revenue attribution or holdings are incorrect, incomplete, duplicated or misattributed

Integrity is the dominant concern. Errors could cause advisors to be overpaid or underpaid, distort business-volume reporting, and propagate into accounting entries and client reporting. Terrapin does not move client money, so errors are typically correctable, but detection can be delayed if the output is trusted without review.

Source data
  |
  v
Aggregation / cleansing
  |
  v
Commission calculation
  |
  v
Payout and accounting inputs
  |
  v
Reporting / reconciliation

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: Terrapin's calculations directly drive compensation and reporting, although the consequence is financial misstatement rather than customer fund movement.

---

8. Data Consequence

The case describes Terrapin as handling portfolio holdings, revenue and advisor compensation data for 38,000 wealth clients.

Data Property	Terrapin Assessment
Confidentiality	High
Integrity	High
Availability	Medium

Confidentiality: Holdings data reveals client wealth positions; compensation data is sensitive employee information. The case does not state that tax IDs or full contact details are included, so Critical is not assigned.

Integrity: Incorrect data affects pay, reporting and accounting.

Availability: Loss of access delays reporting and calculation but is tolerable over short periods.

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: Sensitive client financial and employee compensation data is involved, with significant integrity consequences and moderate availability sensitivity.

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9. Exit and Substitutability

Question: How easily could Meridian replace Terrapin?

Factors to assess: alternative providers, historical data portability, migration of compensation plan logic, source-data feed re-integration, parallel-run and reconciliation, contractual termination terms, and impact on advisors during cutover.

Current platform
    |
    v
Extract history and plan rules
    |
    v
Rebuild source data feeds
    |
    v
Parallel run of compensation cycles
    |
    v
Reconcile against current outputs
    |
    v
Cutover

Substitutes exist in the wealth data and incentive compensation market, and the monthly cadence allows a planned parallel run. However, re-implementing compensation rules and data feeds is not trivial, and the case provides no contract or exit strategy, so no duration should be claimed.

Terrapin Rating: Medium

Reason: Replacement is a planned project rather than a same-day substitution, but the batch cadence and market alternatives make it less constrained than a core platform.

Evidence Gap: Contractual exit terms, data portability rights, alternative providers, internal capability, estimated migration duration.

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10. Regulatory / Compliance Criticality

Question: Could a failure interfere with Meridian's regulated activities?

Terrapin's description includes compliance and reporting solutions for wealth management firms. Potential implications include:

- Accuracy of client and business reporting
- Books-and-records and audit trail for compensation
- Conflict-of-interest and compensation governance for advisors
- Operational resilience expectations for important outsourced services
- Data protection obligations over client holdings

Wealth data and compensation processing
|
v
Reporting and compensation records
|
v
Regulated wealth activity
|
v
Potential compliance and audit impact

The specific regulatory obligations tied to Meridian's use of Terrapin are not provided.

Terrapin Rating: High

Reason: Compensation and reporting accuracy support regulated wealth activity, though the case does not show Terrapin sits in a regulated transaction path.

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11. Financial Materiality

Question: Could Terrapin failure create material financial consequences?

- **Operational:** incident response, rerun and reconciliation effort
- **Advisor:** incorrect or delayed compensation, disputes, retention risk
- **Financial:** over- or under-payment of commissions, accounting corrections
- **Regulatory:** remediation of inaccurate reporting
- **Reputation:** client reporting errors attributed to Meridian

The case does not provide total commission value, advisor headcount, revenue exposure or contractual penalties.

> We can establish the potential for material financial impact, but we should not invent a dollar value.

Terrapin Rating: High Potential Impact

Reason: Compensation errors are directly financial, though exposure is bounded by a monthly review cycle and corrective adjustment.

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12. Concentration / Dependency Risk

Question: Could Meridian's dependence on Terrapin extend across multiple important functions?

Terrapin is positioned as a consolidated data hub that feeds compensation, compliance and reporting. If Meridian uses all of these modules, a single outage or error could hit several functions at once. Terrapin is also dependent on upstream data sources and any custodian or data-aggregator APIs.

The case only establishes the data, reporting and compensation relationship. Module usage should not be assumed.

Terrapin Rating: Medium Potential

Reason: Terrapin may be a single consolidation point across several wealth functions, but it is a niche vendor with no evidence of wider Meridian dependency.

Evidence Gap: Which Terrapin modules Meridian uses, which upstream feeds Terrapin depends on, whether any fourth-party subcontractors host or process Meridian data.

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13. Deep Criticality Matrix

Criticality Dimension	Terrapin Assessment	Score	Key Reason
Business-function centrality	High	3	Advisor compensation and wealth reporting
System-of-record / process authority	High	3	Likely authority for commission calculation; client record not established
Failure blast radius	High	3	38,000 wealth clients, full monthly cycle
Time criticality	Medium	2	Monthly batch cadence

Workaround availability	Medium	2	Deferral and manual fallback plausible, unvalidated
Recoverability	Medium	2	Rerun from source plus reconciliation
Transaction integrity	High	3	Errors drive pay and reporting
Data consequence	High	3	Holdings and compensation data
Exit/substitutability	Medium	2	Planned migration, market alternatives exist
Regulatory impact	High	3	Reporting and compensation records
Financial impact	High Potential	3	Commission mispayment, remediation
Concentration potential	Medium Potential	2	Hub across several functions, unvalidated
Total / Average		**31 / 12 = 2.58**	**High**

Scoring key: Critical = 4, High = 3, Medium = 2, Low = 1. Average of 3.5 or above = Critical; 2.5 to 3.49 = High; 1.5 to 2.49 = Medium; below 1.5 = Low. Any hard trigger overrides the score (see section 15).

---

14. Overall Criticality Conclusion

Recommended Criticality Tier

HIGH

Confidence

Medium-High

Core reasoning

Terrapin's criticality is driven by:

1. Direct role in advisor compensation calculation and wealth reporting
2. Sensitive client holdings and employee compensation data
3. 38,000 wealth clients in scope
4. High integrity consequence, as errors feed pay, accounting and reporting
5. Potential regulatory and audit significance
6. Meaningful but bounded financial exposure

It is held below Critical because:

1. The process is periodic (12 monthly cycles), not real-time
2. Terrapin does not execute payments or hold customer funds
3. Operational dependency is stated as Moderate and the wealth segment is one business line
4. A deferred or manual fallback is plausible within a monthly cycle
5. Reporting and calculation errors are generally detectable and correctable before irreversible customer harm

Wealth data and compensation platform
|
v
Holdings + revenue + advisor compensation data
|
v
38,000 wealth clients, 12 monthly cycles
|
v
High integrity dependency, moderate time sensitivity
|
v

Bounded financial / regulatory consequence
|
v
HIGH

Criticality Rationale (Excel cell): Wealth reporting and advisor compensation platform + sensitive client holdings and pay data for 38,000 wealth clients + high calculation-integrity consequence + potential regulatory and audit significance, offset by monthly batch cadence, no payment execution and plausible deferred fallback = HIGH.

Assessment Depth Applied (Excel cell): ENHANCED. A High tier warrants multi-source OSINT with independent corroboration for any AI claim: vendor product pages and documentation, trust, security and privacy pages, sub-processor list, technical job postings, executive and company channels, partner marketplace listings and press releases. Stop at one primary plus one corroborating source for a positive finding, or after the defined source set returns a negative finding. Direct vendor questionnaire only if AI usage is confirmed or inconclusive on data handling. Broader executive-channel sweeps and contract-level review are reserved for Critical vendors.

---

15. Methodological Insight: Hard Trigger Test

Criticality should not rely solely on an additive score. Layer 2 checks for overrides.

Hard trigger	Met for Terrapin?	Comment
Core transaction processing with no practical immediate workaround	No	Not a transaction processor; batch cadence allows fallback
System-of-record financial processing with material customer impact	Partial	Likely authority for compensation, but customer impact is indirect
Customer-facing function with real-time dependency and high integrity consequence	No	Back-office, periodic

Escalation conditions (re-rate to Critical if validated):

- Terrapin output posts directly to payroll or accounting with no human review
- Terrapin generates client-facing statements or regulatory filings
- Terrapin is the sole copy of source or calculation data with no Meridian retention
- The compensation or reporting deadline cannot tolerate a multi-day delay

---

16. Evidence Gaps That Should Be Investigated

- Meridian's formal RTO and RPO
- Whether output is reviewed before payout or posting
- Retention of source data inside Meridian for independent recalculation
- Advisor headcount and monthly payout value
- Which Terrapin modules are used
- Upstream data feeds and custodian or aggregator APIs
- Contractual exit terms and data portability
- Contractual SLA, penalty and AI clauses
- Fourth-party hosting and sub-processors
- Whether client identifiers or tax IDs are in scope

These are assessment gaps, not assumptions.

---

17. First-Pass OSINT Note (AI Usage)

This is a preliminary position only; the full source sweep for the Enhanced depth is still to be run and logged in the Evidence Log.

Source reviewed	Finding	Evidential weight
Schwab Advisor Services provider listing for Terrapin Technologies	Describes aggregation, automation and management of data, incentive compensation automation, analytics and reporting. No AI, machine learning or model provider is mentioned.	Low: third-party listing, no AI claim

General web search for Terrapin and AI	No Terrapin-specific AI announcement, partner or product found	Negative, search-limited

Working position: AI Usage Detected = **Inconclusive** (not Yes). The word "automation" in marketing copy is not evidence of AI and should be tagged as an ambiguous signal until corroborated.

Next sources to check, in order:

1. terrapintech.com product pages, news and blog
2. Security, privacy and trust pages, and any sub-processor list
3. Terrapin technical job postings (data science, ML, LLM, automation roles)
4. Company and executive LinkedIn posts
5. Press releases, webinars and partner marketplace listings
6. SOC 2 or similar attestation mentions

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18. Provisional AI Security Risk Classification

Classification: Medium (provisional)

Risk rationale (Excel cell): AI usage is not confirmed from public sources reviewed so far. Terrapin handles sensitive client holdings and advisor compensation data, and a High-criticality vendor with unknown AI usage and no published sub-processor information carries residual risk. Rating moves to High if AI is confirmed in data cleansing, calculation or analytics on Meridian data, particularly with an undisclosed model provider; it moves to Low if the Enhanced sweep returns a clear negative finding with a published sub-processor list.

Recommended action (Excel cell): Complete the Enhanced OSINT sweep and log all sources with retrieval dates. Request the vendor's AI and sub-processor disclosure at the next review cycle if AI is confirmed or the sweep stays inconclusive. Confirm contract position on AI training use of Meridian data, sub-processor change notification and human review of calculation outputs.

Final Decision

Terrapin Technologies = HIGH

The strongest justification is not data sensitivity alone. It is the combination of **advisor-compensation and reporting authority, sensitive client and employee financial data, high integrity consequence and potential regulatory significance**, bounded by a **monthly batch cadence, no payment execution and a plausible deferred fallback**. This differentiated rating also shows the methodology discriminates between vendors rather than defaulting everything to Critical.

Fiserv (V-002): Vendor Criticality & AI Security Assessment

Meridian Financial | Optiv Consulting Case Study 1

Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Vendor Profile and Assessment Method
3. Deep Criticality Assessment
4. Criticality Matrix and Final Decision
5. Methodology and Evidence Gaps
6. AI Usage Assessment
7. Evidence Register
8. How Fiserv May Be Using AI
9. Named AI Providers and Collaborators
10. AI Security Risk Classification and Rationale
11. Recommended Actions

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1. Executive Summary

Vendor: Fiserv, Inc. (V-002)
Service: DNA core banking platform
Vendor criticality: **CRITICAL**
AI usage detected: **YES** (corporate and selected product/platform evidence)
AI Security Risk Classification: **HIGH** (DNA-specific AI deployment and data flow remain unverified)
Assessment depth: **DEEP / FULL**

Fiserv is rated **Critical** because it supports core account processing and servicing for a stated population of 1.4 million customers and a stated volume of 240 million transactions, involving customer master data, balances and transactions. Public evidence confirms AI usage across Fiserv's business and selected financial-services products. However, the reviewed public evidence does not establish that AI functionality is enabled in Meridian's specific DNA deployment or that Meridian data is sent to external AI models. The AI security rating is therefore **High**, with deployment-specific validation required.

Assessment Overview

A deeper criticality assessment should consider the following dimensions:

1. Business Function Centrality

2. System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency

3. Failure Blast Radius

4. Time Criticality

5. Workaround Availability

6. Recoverability

7. Transaction Integrity Criticality

8. Data Consequence

9. Exit and Substitutability

10. Regulatory / Compliance Criticality

11. Financial Materiality

12. Concentration / Dependency Risk

---

3. Fiserv Case Context

The provided Meridian vendor profile describes Fiserv as:

- Vendor: **Fiserv, Inc.**

- Service/Product: **DNA core banking platform**

- Category: **Core Platform**

- Business Process: **Core account processing and servicing**

- Operational Dependency: **Critical**

- Data Classification: **Full customer master, balances and transactions**

- Data Volume: **240 million transactions**

- Customer population: **1.4 million customers**

These facts form the baseline for the criticality assessment.

---

4. Business Function Centrality

Question

How central is the vendor's function to Meridian's primary business operations?

Assessment

Fiserv provides the **DNA core banking platform** for:

> Core account processing and servicing

This places the vendor inside a core operational function rather than a peripheral or supporting business process.

The dependency is therefore substantially more important than a vendor providing:

- HR software

- Marketing services

- General productivity software

- Non-critical analytics

- Administrative support

A failure of a core account-processing platform can directly affect the institution's ability to perform its core banking activities.

Fiserv Rating

Critical

Reason

Fiserv supports a core banking process rather than a secondary business function.

---

5. System-of-Record / Process-of-Authority Dependency

Question

Does the vendor merely consume Meridian information, or does it participate in maintaining and processing the operational state of customer accounts?

Assessment

The case states that Fiserv handles:

- Full customer master

- Customer balances

- Customer transactions

This indicates that the relationship extends into the operational processing of customer accounts.

This is materially different from a vendor that simply receives periodic reporting extracts.

A failure or integrity issue in such a dependency could affect:

- Account state

- Balances

- Transactions

- Customer servicing

- Financial records

- Reconciliation processes

Fiserv Rating

Critical

Reason

The dependency is closely associated with the processing and maintenance of customer account information rather than merely secondary use of that information.

---

6. Failure Blast Radius

Question

How broadly would a failure propagate?

Customer Blast Radius

The case indicates:

1.4 million customers

Therefore, the potential customer impact is very large.

Data Blast Radius

The vendor relationship includes:

- Customer master information

- Balances

- Transactions

The potential impact therefore extends across multiple types of customer and financial information.

Transaction Blast Radius

The case gives:

240 million transactions

This indicates extremely high transaction-scale exposure.

A disruption could therefore affect large numbers of financial operations rather than a small isolated workload.

Organizational Blast Radius

Because the vendor supports core account processing, a failure could potentially propagate into:

\`\`\`text

Fiserv Core Platform

|

+--> Account Processing

|

+--> Customer Servicing

|

+--> Transaction Processing

|

+--> Balance / Account State

|

+--> Reconciliation

|

+--> Customer-facing operations

\`\`\`

The exact downstream Meridian systems are not provided and therefore should not be assumed without additional evidence.

Fiserv Rating

Critical

Reason

The customer, data, and transaction blast radius is potentially very large.

---

7. Time Criticality

Question

How quickly does a vendor failure become materially harmful?

Assessment

Fiserv's DNA platform is described publicly as supporting:

24/7 real-time transaction processing

This means the service is inherently time-sensitive.

The dependency should not be treated like a system that can simply remain unavailable for several days without material consequences.

The relevant failure progression is more like:

\`\`\`text

Service interruption

    |

    v

Transaction/account processing disruption

    |

    v

Customer and operational impact

    |

    v

Potential financial/reconciliation consequences

\`\`\`

The case does not provide Meridian's formal RTO, so a specific RTO such as 15 minutes or one hour should not be invented.

However, the real-time nature of the platform provides strong evidence that the tolerance for prolonged outage is low.

Fiserv Rating

Critical

Reason

The supported business process is continuous and time-sensitive rather than periodic.

---

8. Workaround Availability

Question

Can Meridian continue operating normally if Fiserv becomes unavailable?

Manual Workaround

Manual processing of the complete core banking workload at the described scale is unlikely to be practical.

Alternate Platform

No immediate alternative core platform is identified in the provided case material.

Deferred Processing

Some activities may potentially be delayed or queued, but it cannot be assumed that all account and transaction services can safely operate in this way.

Assessment

The combination of:

- Real-time processing

- 1.4 million customers

- 240 million transactions

- Core account processing

makes a complete same-day manual workaround highly implausible.

This does **not** prove that Meridian has no business-continuity or failover capabilities.

That would require additional evidence.

Fiserv Rating

Critical Candidate

Evidence Gap

Further assessment should establish:

- Meridian's BCP arrangement

- Failover architecture

- Alternate processing capability

- Manual fallback procedures

- RTO/RPO

- Maximum tolerable outage

---

9. Recoverability

Question

If Fiserv fails, how quickly and reliably can Meridian restore normal operations?

The recovery chain should be viewed as:

\`\`\`text

Failure

|

v

Detection

|

v

Failover / restoration

|

v

Data recovery

|

v

Transaction reconciliation

|

v

Return to normal operations

\`\`\`

For core financial processing, recovery is not simply about bringing a server back online.

The institution may also need to verify:

- Transaction completeness

- Transaction ordering

- Account balances

- Data consistency

- Reconciliation

- Downstream system synchronization

Therefore, recovery complexity can remain high even when the vendor has strong resilience controls.

Important distinction

High criticality does not mean poor vendor resilience.

A vendor can have strong availability and recovery capabilities while still being classified as Critical because the institution's dependency on that vendor is itself extremely significant.

Fiserv Rating

High consequence / Critical dependency

Evidence Gap

Meridian-specific analysis should obtain:

- RTO

- RPO

- Disaster recovery design

- Failover model

- Recovery testing

- Reconciliation procedures

---

10. Transaction Integrity Criticality

Question

What happens if transactions or financial records are processed incorrectly?

This factor is particularly important for a core banking vendor.

Three dimensions must be considered:

Confidentiality

Unauthorized disclosure of customer financial information.

Availability

Customers and operations cannot access or process required services.

Integrity

Balances or transactions are incorrect, incomplete, duplicated, delayed, or otherwise corrupted.

For a core banking platform, integrity can be particularly severe because incorrect financial state can propagate through:

\`\`\`text

Transaction

|

v

Account state

|

v

Balance

|

v

Ledger / financial records

|

v

Downstream systems

|

v

Reconciliation

\`\`\`

Fiserv Rating

Critical

Reason

The vendor's function is directly related to processing customer account and transaction state.

---

11. Data Consequence

The case describes Fiserv as handling:

> Full customer master, balances and transactions

This means all three dimensions of the CIA triad are significant.

| Data Property | Fiserv Assessment |

|---|---|

| Confidentiality | Critical |

| Integrity | Critical |

| Availability | Critical |

Confidentiality

Exposure could involve sensitive customer and financial information.

Integrity

Incorrect or altered information could affect account state or transaction correctness.

Availability

Loss of access to the information and processing capability could interfere with core banking operations.

Fiserv Rating

Critical

---

12. Exit and Substitutability

Question

How easily could Meridian replace Fiserv?

This is a major criticality indicator.

Factors to assess

- Availability of alternative providers

- Data portability

- Migration duration

- Interface/API replacement

- Integration complexity

- Contractual termination constraints

- Specialized skills

- Customer migration impact

- Testing and reconciliation

- Cutover complexity

A core banking platform is fundamentally different from a simple SaaS application because moving it could involve:

\`\`\`text

Current core platform

|

v

Data extraction

|

v

Data transformation

|

v

Data migration

|

v

Interface replacement

|

v

Testing

|

v

Reconciliation

|

v

Operational transition

|

v

Customer migration / cutover

\`\`\`

Assessment

The case does not provide Meridian's contract or formal exit strategy.

Therefore, we should not claim a specific migration duration.

However, a same-day substitution of a core banking platform is not reasonably established by the available evidence.

Fiserv Rating

High

Evidence Gap

Need Meridian-specific evidence on:

- Contractual exit terms

- Portability rights

- Alternative providers

- Migration plans

- Internal capability

- Estimated migration duration

---

13. Regulatory / Compliance Criticality

Question

Could a failure materially interfere with Meridian's regulated activities?

Fiserv supports a core banking/account-processing function.

The relationship therefore has potential implications for:

- Customer service obligations

- Transaction processing

- Financial record accuracy

- Operational resilience

- Regulatory requirements

- Record integrity

- Business continuity

The criticality is not simply because "Fiserv is a financial technology company."

The stronger logic is:

\`\`\`text

Core banking function

    |

    v

Customer accounts

    |

    v

Transactions / balances

|

v

Regulated financial activity

|

v

Potential compliance and customer impact

\`\`\`

Fiserv Rating

Critical

---

14. Financial Materiality

Question

Could Fiserv failure create material financial consequences?

Potential impact channels include:

Operational

- Service disruption

- Recovery costs

- Operational remediation

Customer

- Delayed or failed customer transactions

- Customer compensation

- Increased support demand

Financial

- Delayed transactions

- Processing losses

- Reconciliation costs

- Potential contractual costs

Regulatory

- Remediation requirements

- Possible regulatory consequences

Reputation

Customers may perceive a failure of a critical third-party platform as a failure of Meridian itself.

The case does not provide Meridian's revenue, transaction values, contractual penalties, or estimated loss figures.

Therefore:

> We can establish the potential for material financial impact, but we should not invent a dollar value.

Fiserv Rating

Critical Potential Impact

---

15. Concentration / Dependency Risk

Question

Could dependence on Fiserv extend across multiple important functions?

This is a more advanced vendor-risk dimension.

Fiserv operates across areas including:

- Account processing

- Payments

- Card processing

- Debit networks

- Bill payment

- P2P payments

- Account-to-account transfers

- Check processing

This creates the possibility of concentration risk if Meridian uses multiple Fiserv services.

However, the case only establishes the DNA relationship.

Therefore:

> **Do not assume Meridian uses all Fiserv services.**

The appropriate conclusion is:

> Fiserv has significant potential for concentration risk because its portfolio spans multiple financial functions, but Meridian-specific concentration must be validated.

Fiserv Rating

High Potential

Evidence Gap

Determine whether Meridian has additional:

- Fiserv payment services

- Card services

- Fraud services

- Network services

- Other Fiserv platforms

---

16. Deep Criticality Matrix

| Criticality Dimension | Fiserv Assessment | Key Reason |

|---|---|---|

| Business-function centrality | Critical | Core banking/account processing |

| System-of-record / process authority | Critical | Customer accounts, balances and transactions |

| Customer blast radius | Critical | 1.4M customers |

| Transaction blast radius | Critical | 240M transactions |

| Time criticality | Critical | 24/7 real-time processing |

| Workaround availability | Critical Candidate | No same-day equivalent workaround established |

| Recoverability consequence | High | Recovery and reconciliation can be complex |

| Data confidentiality | Critical | Full customer information |

| Data integrity | Critical | Account and transaction state |

| Data availability | Critical | Core processing dependency |

| Exit/substitutability | High | Core platform replacement is potentially complex |

| Regulatory impact | Critical | Core banking and transaction processing |

| Financial impact | Critical Potential | Material operational/customer consequences |

| Concentration potential | High Potential | Fiserv spans multiple financial functions |

---

17. Overall Criticality Conclusion

Recommended Criticality Tier

CRITICAL

Confidence

Very High

Core reasoning

Fiserv's criticality is driven by the combination of:

1. **Core business-function centrality**

2. **Direct account and transaction processing**

3. **Large customer blast radius**

4. **Very high transaction volume**

5. **24/7 real-time processing**

6. **High data confidentiality requirements**

7. **High transaction/data integrity requirements**

8. **Low apparent immediate substitutability**

9. **Potentially complex recovery and reconciliation**

10. **Potential customer, regulatory and financial consequences**

The conclusion is therefore substantially stronger than simply saying:

> "Fiserv handles sensitive data, therefore it is Critical."

The appropriate reasoning is:

\`\`\`text

Core banking platform

        |

v

Core account processing

|

v

Customer accounts + balances + transactions

|

v

1.4M customers + 240M transactions

|

v

Real-time operational dependency

|

v

Large customer and transaction blast radius

|

v

High integrity + availability consequences

|

v

Limited immediate workaround/substitution

|

v

Potential financial/regulatory/customer consequences

|

v

CRITICAL

\`\`\`

---

18. Important Methodological Insight

Criticality should not rely solely on an additive score.

A mature methodology should have **two layers**:

Layer 1 — Weighted Scoring

Use multiple dimensions to score normal vendor relationships.

Layer 2 — Criticality Override / Hard Triggers

Certain combinations should automatically trigger a Critical review.

Examples:

> **Core transaction processing + no practical immediate workaround → Critical candidate**

> **System-of-record financial processing + material customer impact → Critical candidate**

> **Critical customer-facing function + real-time dependency + high integrity consequence → Critical candidate**

This prevents an important vendor from receiving a lower rating merely because one numerical factor happens to be small.

---

19. Evidence Gaps That Should Be Investigated

The current assessment is strong, but a full real-world Meridian assessment should still establish:

- Meridian's formal RTO

- Meridian's formal RPO

- Actual failover architecture

- Business continuity arrangements

- Alternate processing capability

- Manual fallback procedures

- Contractual exit terms

- Data portability

- Migration strategy

- Actual downstream system dependencies

- Additional Fiserv services used by Meridian

- Concentration across multiple Fiserv products

- Transaction-value exposure

- Contractual SLA/penalty structure

These should be treated as **assessment gaps**, not assumptions.

Final Decision

Fiserv = CRITICAL

The strongest justification is not simply its size.

The strongest justification is the **combination of core banking functionality, transaction processing, customer-scale exposure, real-time dependency, data/transaction integrity requirements, limited immediate substitutability, and potentially material customer, financial, operational and regulatory consequences.**

\
Criticality Rationale

Core banking function + real-time transaction processing + 1.4M customers + 240M transactions + sensitive customer/balance data + high operational, financial and regulatory impact + limited immediate substitutability = CRITICAL.

DEEP / FULL — Critical core-banking dependency requires broad multi-source OSINT, independent corroboration, detailed evidence capture, and deeper investigation of AI usage and third-party dependencies

\

AI Usage Detected: YES

- **[CORPORATE_DISCLOSURE] [CONFIRMED]** Fiserv's FY2025 Form 10-K explicitly confirms AI/ML use in product development, services and operations.\
  Source:[SEC Form 10-K, FY2025](https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm)\
  Evidence strength: Very high — primary regulatory filing.
- **[PRODUCT_EVIDENCE] [CONFIRMED_PRODUCT]** Check Fraud Defender uses AI-driven check-image analysis for fraud detection.\
  Source:[Fiserv — Check Fraud Defender](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/deposit-solutions/check-risk-mitigation/check-fraud-defender.html)\
  Evidence strength: Very high — official product documentation.
- **[PRODUCT_EVIDENCE] [CONFIRMED_PRODUCT]** AML Risk Manager uses AI-driven risk scoring to analyze transaction patterns and customer behavior in real time.\
  Source:[Fiserv — AML Risk Manager](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager.html)\
  Evidence strength: Very high — official product documentation.
- **[TECHNICAL_HIRING] [CAPABILITY_SIGNAL]** Fiserv's Applied Production Machine Learning Engineer job posting describes production ML services for real-time decision-making across payments and financial services.\
  Source:[Official Fiserv job posting](https://fiserv.wd5.myworkdayjobs.com/en-US/EXT/job/Software-Development-Engineer--AI---ML-_R-10373747)\
  Evidence strength: Supporting — demonstrates engineering capability, not standalone proof of deployment.
- **[SCOPE_LIMITATION] [UNVERIFIED]** Public evidence confirms AI usage across Fiserv's business and specific financial-services products. Whether AI functionality is enabled in Meridian's specific DNA deployment, and whether Meridian data is processed by external AI models, remains unverified.

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Evidence Description — Fiserv (V-002)

- **[CORPORATE_DISCLOSURE] [CONFIRMED_CORPORATE] [HIGH EVIDENCE]** — Fiserv's FY2025 Form 10-K explicitly states that it uses and expects to expand AI/ML in "product development processes, services and operations." It also acknowledges that some services integrating third-party AI models may rely on provider safeguards. This is the strongest evidence of corporate-level AI usage.\
  Source: SEC Form 10-K —[
https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm](https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm)
- **[PRODUCT_DOCUMENTATION] [CONFIRMED_PRODUCT] [HIGH EVIDENCE]** — Fiserv's AML Risk Manager documentation explicitly describes AI-driven risk scoring that analyses transaction patterns and customer behaviour in real time. Its Enhanced Analytics documentation also identifies machine-learning models for alert scoring and prioritisation.\
  Sources:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager.html)\

https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager/aml-risk-manager-enhanced-analytics.html
- **[PRODUCT_DOCUMENTATION] [CONFIRMED_PRODUCT] [HIGH EVIDENCE]** — Check Fraud Defender is described as combining AI-driven check-image analysis with a cloud-hosted check-image consortium to detect check fraud across mobile, branch, ATM and back-office channels. The page identifies Mitek as a partner in the offering.\
  Source:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/deposit-solutions/check-risk-mitigation/check-fraud-defender.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/deposit-solutions/check-risk-mitigation/check-fraud-defender.html)
- **[PLATFORM_ANNOUNCEMENT] [CONFIRMED_PLATFORM] [HIGH EVIDENCE]** — Fiserv's May 14, 2026 announcement describes agentOS, an AI-agent platform designed for banking workflows across core, payments, issuer-processing and servicing platforms. Initial agents include commercial loan onboarding, operational analysis/reporting, deposit intelligence and AML triage. The announcement also identifies AWS Bedrock and AgentCore as infrastructure collaborators.\
  Source:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking)
- **[SCOPE_LIMITATION] [UNVERIFIED]** — Public sources establish corporate AI usage and AI-enabled capabilities in specific Fiserv offerings. They do **not**, by themselves, establish

that AI is enabled in Meridian's specific DNA deployment or that Meridian's customer, balance or transaction data is sent to an external AI model. Those points require deployment-specific documentation and data-flow validation.

Research date: 2026-10-10.\
Overall evidence assessment: Strong evidence of Fiserv corporate and product-level AI usage; DNA-specific usage and Meridian data exposure remain unverified.

How Vendor May Be Using AI — Fiserv (V-002)

- **[CONFIRMED_CORPORATE] [HIGH CONFIDENCE] AI-assisted product development and operations:** Fiserv states in its FY2025 Form 10-K that it uses AI and machine learning in product development, services and operations.\
  Source:[
https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm](https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm)
- **[CONFIRMED_PLATFORM] [HIGH CONFIDENCE] Agentic banking workflows:** Fiserv's agentOS platform is designed to operate across its core, payments, issuer-processing and servicing platforms. Announced use cases include commercial loan onboarding, operational reporting, deposit intelligence and AML triage. These agents could support workflows connected to core banking, but public evidence does not confirm their activation in Meridian's specific DNA deployment.\
  Source:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking)
- **[CONFIRMED_PRODUCT] [HIGH CONFIDENCE] Transaction monitoring and risk scoring:** Fiserv's AML Risk Manager uses AI-driven risk scoring to analyse transaction patterns and customer behaviour in real time, supporting suspicious-activity detection and alert prioritisation.\
  Source:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/risk-compliance/aml-risk-manager.html)
- **[CONFIRMED_PRODUCT] [HIGH CONFIDENCE] Fraud detection:** Fiserv's Check Fraud Defender uses AI-driven check-image analysis and shared intelligence to identify potential check fraud across multiple processing channels. This demonstrates AI usage elsewhere in Fiserv's financial-services portfolio, not necessarily in DNA itself.\
  Source:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/deposit-solutions/check-risk-mitigation/check-fraud-defender.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/deposit-solutions/check-risk-mitigation/check-fraud-defender.html)
- **[INFERENCE] [REQUIRES VALIDATION] Potential DNA-related applications:** Given DNA's role in real-time account processing and its configurable integration architecture, potential adjacent applications include transaction analytics, fraud or AML integrations, operational

reporting, and AI-agent-assisted banking workflows. These are plausible integration scenarios, not confirmed AI capabilities within the DNA core engine.\
  Source:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/about-fiserv/resource-center/brochures/dna.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/about-fiserv/resource-center/brochures/dna.html)
- **[SCOPE_LIMITATION] [UNVERIFIED] Deployment and data flow:** Public sources do not establish whether Meridian's DNA instance has AI-enabled features switched on, which specific customer or transaction fields any AI component can access, or whether Meridian data is transmitted to external models. These details require deployment-specific documentation and data-flow validation.

Conclusion: Fiserv demonstrably uses AI across its business and financial-services product portfolio. AI-assisted banking workflows and analytics may extend to core-platform environments, but AI use within Meridian's specific DNA deployment remains unconfirmed.

Fiserv (V-002) — Named AI Sub-processors / Model Providers

- **[NAMED_AI_PROVIDER] [PUBLICLY_CONFIRMED] OpenAI:** Fiserv publicly announced a strategic collaboration with OpenAI to develop selected AI agents for banking workflows on its agentOS platform.\
  Source:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-forms-strategic-collaboration-openai-bring-ai-how-fiserv](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-forms-strategic-collaboration-openai-bring-ai-how-fiserv)
- **[AI_INFRASTRUCTURE_PROVIDER] [PUBLICLY_CONFIRMED] Amazon Web Services (AWS):** Fiserv states that agentOS uses Amazon Bedrock for access to AI models and runs on Amazon Bedrock AgentCore.\
  Source:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking)
- **[ENTERPRISE_AI_PROVIDER] [PUBLICLY_CONFIRMED] Microsoft:** Fiserv has publicly disclosed its use of Microsoft Foundry, Microsoft 365 Copilot and GitHub Copilot for AI development, workforce productivity and related innovation. The announcement does not establish that these tools process Meridian's DNA data.\
  Source:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-collaborates-microsoft-accelerate-ai-driven-innovation](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-collaborates-microsoft-accelerate-ai-driven-innovation)
- **[SCOPE_LIMITATION] [UNVERIFIED]** These are publicly named AI providers or collaborators in Fiserv's broader AI ecosystem, not confirmed sub-processors for Meridian's specific DNA deployment. No reviewed public source establishes that OpenAI, AWS or Microsoft receives Meridian's DNA customer records, balances or transaction data.

Assessment: OpenAI; Amazon Web Services (Amazon Bedrock / Bedrock AgentCore); Microsoft (Microsoft Foundry / Microsoft 365 Copilot / GitHub Copilot). DNA-specific provider relationships and data-processing scope remain unverified.

HIGH

Fiserv is a critical core-banking vendor handling highly sensitive customer, balance and transaction data. Its public disclosures confirm corporate AI use, and its agentOS platform is designed to operate across core banking and other financial-services platforms. Third-party AI providers are also publicly named. However, public evidence does not confirm that AI models process Meridian's specific DNA data.

Why High rather than Critical? The business impact and potential exposure are substantial, but the specific AI-to-Meridian-data flow remains unverified. Upgrade to Critical if further evidence confirms sensitive Meridian data is exposed to AI models or AI agents can perform consequential banking actions without adequate controls.

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Risk Rationale — Fiserv (V-002)

[HIGH RISK] [CRITICAL DEPENDENCY] [SENSITIVE DATA] [AI DATA FLOW UNVERIFIED]

Fiserv supports Meridian's core account processing and servicing, with access to customer master data, balances and transactions for 1.4 million customers and a stated annual volume of 240 million transactions. A security or processing failure could therefore have substantial customer, financial and operational consequences. Fiserv's FY2025 Form 10-K confirms corporate use of AI/ML, while its agentOS announcement describes AI agents designed to operate across core banking, payments and servicing platforms, with OpenAI and AWS as collaborators. These disclosures establish meaningful AI-related risk potential, but do not prove that Meridian's DNA deployment uses these agents or transmits Meridian data to their models. The HIGH rating reflects the combination of critical service dependency, sensitive financial data and confirmed broader AI activity, with uncertainty around deployment scope, data flows, model retention, training use, access controls and human oversight. **No actual AI-related data exposure is established by the reviewed public evidence.**

Sources:

- SEC FY2025 Form 10-K:[
https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm](https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/798354/000079835426000009/fi-20251231.htm)
- Fiserv agentOS announcement:[
https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operati

ng-system-agentic-ai-banking](https://investors.fiserv.com/news-releases/news-release-details/fiserv-launches-agentos-operating-system-agentic-ai-banking)
- Fiserv DNA platform:[
https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/core-platforms-for-banks/dna-platform.html](https://www.fiserv.com/en/solutions/core-platforms-for-banks/dna-platform.html)

Recommended Action — Fiserv (V-002)

- **[PRIORITY: HIGH] [DEPLOYMENT_VALIDATION]** — Establish whether AI features or agentic workflows are enabled in Meridian's specific DNA environment. Do not assume broader Fiserv AI capabilities are active in this deployment.
- **[DATA_FLOW_REVIEW] [SENSITIVE_DATA]** — Map the customer, account, balance and transaction data accessible to any AI component. Identify where data is processed, stored, logged or transmitted.
- **[THIRD_PARTY_RISK] [SUBPROCESSOR_VALIDATION]** — Verify the specific AI models, model providers and sub-processors used by the DNA deployment. Confirm data-retention periods, model-training use, data isolation and applicable contractual protections.
- **[SECURITY_CONTROLS] [CONTROL_ASSURANCE]** — Review access restrictions, encryption, monitoring, human oversight, output validation, audit logging and mechanisms to disable AI functionality safely.
- **[DECISION_GATE] [REASSESSMENT_REQUIRED]** — Do not enable unassessed AI integrations that could access sensitive banking data or initiate consequential transactions until the required controls have been validated. Reassess the AI security rating when deployment-specific evidence becomes available.

Assessment constraint: For this exercise, base findings on public OSINT and permitted existing material; do not contact Fiserv directly.

Vendor 3 FSSI — Deep Criticality Assessment

Financial Statement Services, Inc. (FSSI) rates HIGH, not Critical: it holds the full customer population's identity and tax data, but it sits in a days-tolerant, non-money-movement flow with realistic alternatives.

Rating at a glance

One dimension is Critical (data), seven are High and four are Medium. Meridian's own inventory rates FSSI's operational dependency Moderate, against High for BNY, which is the main reason it lands a tier lower than BNY. After reading about 20 FSSI and partner pages, one rating moved up (system of record, Medium to High) and the tier did not change.

#	Dimension	Rating	Key reason	Evidence status
1	Business function centrality	High	Produces mandated customer statements, tax forms and regulatory notices; moves no money	Confirmed (inventory, FSSI banks page)
2	System of record	High	FSSI's pages confirm it holds proof of mailing, e-notice consent and an archive; whether Meridian keeps its own copy is unknown	Partly confirmed
3	Failure blast radius	High	About 19M documents a year across the whole customer base; impact is communications, not account operations	Partly known

4	Time criticality	Medium (High in deadline windows)	Tolerates days, not weeks; fixed statement cycles and the January tax-form deadline; no recovery time published	Service characteristics
5	Workaround availability	Medium	Other print-mail providers exist, but print, e-notice and SMS all run through FSSI; archive export options reduce lock-in	Partly confirmed
6	Recoverability	Medium	Reprint from source data is possible; FSSI states SAN replication from Santa Ana to Dallas, but no recovery time, recovery point or test result	Partly confirmed
7	Document and record integrity	High	A wrong address or figure means a disclosure or dispute; FSSI describes piece-level tracking and proof approval that lower the likelihood	Controls claimed, effectiveness unknown
8	Data consequence	Critical	Names, addresses, account numbers, balances and tax identifiers for the entire customer base, plus email, mobile and log-in data	Confirmed
9	Exit and substitutability	Medium	Many providers; custom per-client programs and e-notice re-enrolment make the move costly	Partly confirmed

10	Regulatory and compliance	High	Statutory notices and tax forms; attestation scope, auditor and dates not published	Attestation scope unknown
11	Financial materiality	High (potential)	Driven by breach cost at full-population scale, not by outage cost	Monetary impact unknown
12	Concentration and dependency	High (potential)	Print, e-notice, SMS partner and one data feed in a single vendor; recent acquisition adds integration risk	Partly confirmed

Overall tier: HIGH. Confidence: medium-high.

1. Business function centrality

Rating: High. FSSI produces and distributes printed account statements and IRS tax documents, produces regulatory notices and hosts the electronic notice platform. Customer communication is a core obligation of a bank, but it follows account activity rather than driving it: accounts, balances and payments keep working if FSSI is down. Unlike BNY or Fiserv, FSSI is not in the transaction path.

Gap: which statement and notice types FSSI produces, and the split between print and electronic.

Public evidence: FSSI's banks page lists checking, savings, wealth and commercial statements, overdraft notifications, adverse action letters, rate modification notices, escrow disclosures and 1099, 1098 and 5498 tax documents, and says it supports FDIC, CFPB and GLBA compliance. That matches the inventory and confirms the scope.

2. System-of-record / process-of-authority dependency

Rating: High. FSSI renders documents from data Meridian supplies; the authoritative account data stays in the core platform (V-002, Fiserv). FSSI's own pages, however, show it holds records that prove a customer was served, so it is more than a printer. Whether Meridian keeps its own copy of these is not established:

- The archive of rendered statements and notices.

- Proof of mailing and presentment, and customers' electronic-delivery consent and enrolment, through the e-notice platform it hosts.

The second matters most: it answers whether a customer was validly served.

Gap: document-of-record ownership, archive retention period, where consent records live, and whether Meridian can regenerate documents without FSSI.

Public evidence: the regulatory compliance page describes unique piece tracking, USPS Intelligent Mail barcode scans, proof of mailing and certified-mail return receipts "posted to FSSI's portal". The electronic presentment page describes "Unlimited Archival Capacity" and registration that captures "the Electronic Communications Agreement". Rating raised from Medium to High on this evidence.

3. Failure blast radius

Rating: High, not Critical. The inventory gives 19 million documents a year and says the data covers the entire customer base. The inventory's other vendor row (V-002) gives 1.4 million customers, so FSSI's population is probably about 1.4 million; that is an inference to confirm. As a sanity check, 19M over 1.4M customers is roughly 13.6 documents each: twelve monthly statements plus notices and tax forms.

Affected: statements, notices, tax documents, access to the e-notice platform, and the contact-centre and complaint volume that follows. Not affected: payments, balances, account access.

Public evidence: FSSI says its service "scales from thousands to millions of pieces per cycle" (banks page), so Meridian's volume is within what it claims to run. Its July 2025 merger with Cathedral Corporation's Business Services Division (press room) is a change to watch.

4. Time criticality

Rating: Medium, High in deadline windows. The failure runs:

1. FSSI outage.
2. A statement or notice cycle is missed.
3. A fixed deadline is missed.
4. Customer complaints, disputes and possible penalties.

Statements run monthly, so an outage of a few days is absorbed unless it hits a cycle cut-off. The pressure points are fixed dates: most information returns reach recipients by 31 January, and some account-term changes carry advance-notice periods (for example 30 days for deposit accounts). Meridian's actual form and notice list must confirm which apply.

Gap: Meridian's recovery time objective for statements and notices, and FSSI's contractual service levels.

Public evidence: the secure data processing page says files can be uploaded "day or night" and a PDF approval file is produced before final distribution. The workStreamOne portal page reports SLA metrics on pieces mailed early, on time or late. The banks page promises "short-window turnaround times" on tax documents. No statutory deadlines, recovery time or service levels are published.

5. Workaround availability

Rating: Medium. Options exist but none is confirmed:

- A second print-mail provider, or Meridian's own print capability.
- Switching customers to electronic delivery, which needs prior electronic consent.
- Deferring a cycle within its tolerance.

The weak point is that print and the e-notice platform both sit with FSSI, so falling back from one channel to the other does not remove FSSI from the path. Customers without e-consent can only be served on paper.

Gap: secondary provider, in-house capability, share of customers with e-consent, manual fallback for urgent notices.

Public evidence: eStreamOne offers three hosting models: API, single sign-on and fully hosted. Under fully hosted, FSSI handles log-in and password resets, so customer access to e-statements stops with FSSI. Archives can be delivered on DVD or uploaded to a client's in-house archive, which helps. eDelivery can "generate a mailpiece when an email recipient is unreachable". The same page offers online bill payment through PayNearMe; if Meridian uses it, FSSI is closer to a payment flow than the inventory says.

6. Recoverability

Rating: Medium. Recovery is more than restarting a print run:

1. Detect the failure.
2. Fail over; FSSI states it runs four redundant facilities (Santa Ana, Coppell, Lincoln, Orlando) with replication and fail-over.
3. Re-send or re-run Meridian's source files.
4. Establish which documents were printed, mailed or delivered.
5. Reprint or resend only the gaps, without duplicates.
6. Reconcile counts and confirm completeness.

Two features make this harder than a normal batch job. Mail already in the postal stream cannot be recalled, and a duplicated statement is itself a second disclosure of the same personal data. Rated Medium because the source data can be re-sent from Meridian's side.

Gap: recovery time and point objectives, batch-level restart controls, last disaster-recovery test, reconciliation procedure.

Public evidence: the infrastructure page says the "Santa Ana SAN is continuously replicated to the Dallas SAN" and mentions "internal replication and fail-over features"; recovery time, recovery point and testing are not stated. The locations page lists print and mail at Coppell, Orlando and Lincoln, describes Santa Ana as headquarters, and names no disaster-recovery site. The home page's claim of four "fully redundant" facilities is therefore not backed by any described site-to-site failover; job postings for mail roles in Santa Ana suggest it also produces mail. Confirm both.

7. Document and record integrity

Rating: High. The BNY example rates payment-instruction integrity Critical because a bad message moves money. FSSI's outputs do not move money, but errors are visible and regulated:

- A statement inserted into the wrong envelope or sent to a stale address discloses account data at scale.
- A data-mapping error prints wrong balances or dates.
- Wrong amounts or tax identifiers on tax documents force corrected filings.
- Missing or late notices breach delivery obligations.
- An e-notice sent to the wrong recipient.

FSSI's site describes "automated cross-checking and verifications" for quality control; how well that works at Meridian's volume is not established.

Public evidence: inserters use "camera systems for 100% Unique Piece Tracking (UPT) authentication" and a 2D barcode on every document (infrastructure page); the infrastructure page also cites "peer reviews and double sign-offs" and an independent QA team. Clients review PDF samples before release, so Meridian's own sample approval is a control it must actually perform.

8. Data consequence

Rating: Critical. The inventory lists names, addresses, account numbers, balances and tax identifiers for the entire customer base. The e-notice service also uses email addresses and mobile numbers (its eDelivery service sends email and text alerts) and, in the fully hosted model, customer log-in credentials, which the inventory does not list.

Property	Rating	Why
Confidentiality	Critical	Full-population identity plus tax identifiers is enough for identity theft; breach notification would run to roughly 1.4M people
Integrity	High	Wrong figures or recipients cause disputes and corrected filings
Availability	Medium	Delay is tolerated for days, as in dimension 4

Gap: retention, encryption, data location, and any subcontracted print or mail-house steps.

Public evidence: files move by SFTP and are protected with "PGP encryption for files at rest"; input files are archived and then destroyed "based on business rules" with no retention period stated. SMS runs through a named partner, Solutions by Text, via a custom API. The privacy policy lists "service providers and contractors" but no sub-processor register. FSSI's pages do not name subcontracted print or mail steps and describe an in-house, on-premises environment.

9. Exit and substitutability

Rating: Medium. Print-mail and electronic-delivery outsourcing is a mature market with many providers, so a replacement exists. The cost is in the move, not in finding one:

- Rebuilding document templates and data mappings.
- Re-approving regulatory notice wording.
- Postal certification and parallel runs.
- Moving the archive.
- Re-platforming e-notice, including re-obtaining electronic consent where it cannot be ported.

No migration duration is assumed here; the case gives no contract terms.

Gap: contractual exit terms, archive portability, alternative providers, estimated cutover time.

Public evidence: the secure data processing page says "Custom programs are built for each client", so the data mapping is FSSI-specific and would need rebuilding. Input formats are standard (flat files, XML, PDF, AFP, PCL), which helps a new provider. Archive export options exist, but no exit or transition terms are published.

10. Regulatory and compliance criticality

Rating: High, not Critical. FSSI is not in a payment or transaction flow, but it delivers documents the law requires. Assuming a US regime, because the inventory cites IRS documents:

- Periodic statements and account-term notices to customers.
- Information returns to recipients and the IRS, with penalties for late or incorrect forms.
- Privacy and safeguarding duties for customer data, and breach notification.
- Third-party-risk expectations: Meridian stays accountable for what FSSI does on its behalf.

Gap: Meridian's jurisdictions and its actual list of notices and forms sent through FSSI.

Public evidence: FSSI claims SOC 2, HITRUST CSF and HIPAA compliance. The SOC 2 and HITRUST page does not state the SOC 2 type, the trust criteria covered, the locations in scope, the auditor or any dates, and does not say which HITRUST assessment was passed. The only audit result found is a December 2022 press item reporting a SOC 2 audit "with zero exceptions in all locations" (press room). The attestation therefore has to be requested and read, not assumed. Adverse action letters and escrow disclosures carry statutory timing rules, so the notice inventory matters here.

11. Financial materiality

Rating: High (potential). The case gives volume (19 million documents) but no revenue exposure, penalty terms or loss estimate, so no dollar figure is stated here. The likely cost driver is a breach, not an outage:

- **Breach:** notification, forensics, credit monitoring and regulator response for about 1.4M people.
- **Compliance:** penalties on late or wrong tax forms; customer remediation.
- **Operational:** reprint, postage, rework and extra contact-centre volume.

12. Concentration and dependency risk

Rating: High (potential). Concentration sits inside the vendor as much as across vendors:

- Print, e-notice and the same customer data feed run through one operator, so the channels are not independent.

- FSSI's input comes from the core platform (V-002), so a Fiserv extract failure also stops FSSI output.
- FSSI lists a related brand, Splash Direct Mail; whether Meridian uses it for marketing is unknown.

Gap: other services Meridian buys from FSSI, its subcontractors (print, mail, SMS and email delivery), and the partner ecosystem.

Public evidence: named dependencies on FSSI's side are Solutions by Text (SMS), PayNearMe (payments), Pitney Bowes Presort Services and USPS (mail), and a partnership with InvoiceCloud to "deliver a unified solution" (partner page). FSSI also runs workStreamOne, its job-tracking portal on a separate domain, and Splash Direct Mail. None of these appears in the inventory, so Meridian should ask which of them touch its data.

AI risk: initial view

No AI use is evidenced in FSSI's own service after opening about 20 pages: product, security, compliance, press, blog, privacy policy, careers and a partner page (see the evidence log). Suggested entry for column O: **No**, recorded as a negative finding rather than a guarantee. FSSI's automation wording describes rule-based file tracking, data validation and optical scanning on inserters, and statement messaging runs on "pre-defined, data-driven variables". Its 16 openings include one Software Engineer and one SQL Database Administrator and nothing AI-related, and it says it builds "proprietary software and tools" in-house, which points away from outside model providers.

The one AI reference found sits on InvoiceCloud's site, not FSSI's: a banner reading "AI that answers billing questions instantly, grounded in real account details". It matters only if Meridian uses the joint FSSI and InvoiceCloud solution, which the inventory does not say.

Because the data consequence is Critical, even a small AI use would carry high risk. Rated if AI were found:

Risk	Impact	Evidence	Gap
Data exposure	Low today	No AI found; data handled on FSSI's own infrastructure with SFTP and PGP	Whether any partner (SMS, e-payment, CRM) applies AI to Meridian data

Model error	Low	Messaging is rule-based; piece tracking is barcode-based	None found
Provider dependency	Low to Medium	No model provider named; named third parties are Solutions by Text, PayNearMe, Pitney Bowes Presort Services and InvoiceCloud, none shown to supply AI to FSSI	No sub-processor register published
Transparency	Medium	Privacy policy has no AI or sub-processor wording; SOC 2 scope and auditor not stated	Ask in the questionnaire

Suggested column S: **Low** (none identified for FSSI's own service), to be revisited if Meridian uses the InvoiceCloud solution or the vendor questionnaire reveals AI in messaging or address processing.

Evidence log

Page	What it showed	AI wording
FSSI home	Services, four facilities, SOC 2 and HITRUST claims, QC and automation wording	None
Infrastructure	SFTP, PGP at rest, SAN replication Santa Ana to Dallas, piece tracking, no RTO or RPO	None
SOC 2 and HITRUST	Generic description; no type, scope, auditor or date	None

Electronic presentment	eStreamOne hosting models, archive, consent, PayNearMe	None
eDelivery	Email and SMS alerts, Solutions by Text, opt-in consent	None
Secure data processing	Input formats, SFTP, file checks, PDF approval, input-file destruction	None
Statement messaging	Rule-based variable messages and click reports	None
Regulatory compliance	Piece tracking, IMb, proof of mailing, certified mail	None
Workflow tracking	workStreamOne portal, SLA and postage reporting	None
Banks	Document types, FDIC, CFPB and GLBA claims, tax forms	None
Dependability	In-house proprietary tools, Pitney Bowes Presort, USPS	None
Locations	Four sites, no DR site named	None
Press room	Cathedral merger (July 2025), 2022 audit results, 2025 innovation award	None

Blog	Eight post titles; only an "Automation" tag	None
Privacy policy	Website third-party services, retention schedule, no sub-processor list	None
Careers (jobs list)	16 roles; Software Engineer and SQL DBA are the only technical ones	None
InvoiceCloud partner page	Unified solution with FSSI, modified October 2025	Yes, but InvoiceCloud's banner and menu, not FSSI's
workStreamOne login	FSSI-branded two-factor login	None

AutomWorx — Vendor Criticality & AI Security Assessment

Case: Optiv Consulting Case Study 1 — Vendor AI Usage Analysis
Organization: Meridian Financial (fictional case-study organization)
Vendor: AutomWorx (V-001)
Research date: 12 October 2026
Scope: Public OSINT only; no vendor contact. Meridian-specific deployment facts are not inferred from general product capability.

Executive summary

Recommended criticality tier: HIGH. AutomWorx is a specialist provider for implementation, migration, modernization, and support of the enterprise workload-automation estate used for batch scheduling across Meridian's core systems. The supplied inventory records **High** operational dependency and privileged access to production job schedules, system configuration, and service credentials. A compromise or operational error could therefore affect multiple scheduled workflows and their downstream systems. The inventory says **no direct customer data** is accessed and provides no annual volume, so a Critical rating is not established by the supplied facts alone.

Recommended assessment depth: DEEP / HIGH-TIER. Privileged production access justifies review of service details, custom integration activities, product-version and AI-feature capabilities, provider/data-flow options, access controls, and internal deployment evidence.

AI usage detected: YES — in the publicly marketed service offering, with a deployment caveat. AutomWorx publicly says it helps customers evaluate, implement, and configure Automic Automation V26. AutomWorx's V26 article describes the platform's AI assistant, model connectivity, AI-assisted scripting/workflow construction, and agentic AI capabilities. A separate AutomWorx article discusses the risks of AI agents interacting with systems through existing service accounts and credentials. These sources support the presence of AI-enabled capabilities in the service offering; they **do not prove** that AI is enabled in Meridian's environment or used by AutomWorx against Meridian systems.

Recommended AI security risk: MODERATE (provisional). The potential consequence is material because the vendor has privileged access around core-system batch scheduling. However, the evidence does not establish a live AI deployment, an AI-to-Meridian data flow, or an identified model provider for Meridian. Raise the rating to **HIGH** if internal evidence shows that AI features or agents can access production configurations, logs, stored credentials, or execute production jobs; keep it lower only if the AI features are confirmed disabled or tightly isolated.

1. Vendor profile from the supplied workbook

- **Vendor ID / name:** V-001 — AutomWorx
- **Description:** An independent consulting firm specializing in workload automation solutions, including AppWorx, UC4 and Automic software implementation and related consulting services.
- **Service provided to Meridian:** Implementation, migration, managed support and modernization of the enterprise workload automation and batch scheduling estate.
- **Category:** Professional Services
- **Business process supported:** Batch scheduling across core systems
- **Operational dependency:** High (provided value)
- **Data classification accessed:** No direct customer data. Privileged access to production job schedules, system configuration and service credentials.
- **Annual data volume:** Not applicable (provided value)

The profile above is from the workbook. The operational, security, and AI implications below are assessments, not additional facts about Meridian's architecture.

2. Recommended workbook entries

Criticality Tier

HIGH

Criticality Rationale

AutomWorx supports batch scheduling across Meridian's core systems and is assigned High operational dependency in the vendor inventory. The supplied profile also states that AutomWorx has privileged access to production job schedules, system configuration, and service credentials. Loss or misuse of that access could disrupt scheduled processing or enable unauthorized changes across connected systems. The workbook states that AutomWorx has no direct customer-data access and does not provide a transaction or data-volume figure. On the evidence supplied, **High** is more defensible than Critical: the operational reach is significant, but exclusive control of the scheduler, standing unrestricted administration, inability for Meridian staff to recover jobs, and exact downstream dependencies are not established. Escalate to Critical if internal evidence confirms one or more of those conditions.

Assessment Depth Applied

DEEP / HIGH-TIER REVIEW. Review official service descriptions and custom-integration activities; AI capabilities of the supported Automic platform; public statements about AI-agent governance; privacy and third-party-sharing terms; supported model options; and Meridian's internal implementation, access, change, and configuration records. Because the vendor has privileged production access, examine not only customer-data exposure but also credentials, job definitions, execution logs, scripts, and the ability to initiate or alter production workloads. Depth is driven by the High tier and privileged access, not by the volume of public material. Stop

short of asserting deployment-specific conclusions where public evidence cannot establish them; no vendor contact is permitted under the case instructions.

AI Usage Detected (Y/N)

YES — AI-enabled capabilities are explicitly included in the workload-automation service offering AutomWorx markets and supports. This is a service-offering finding, **not** confirmation that Meridian's installed version has AI enabled or that AI currently processes Meridian information.

Evidence Description along with OSINT Source(s) / Evidence Link

Primary source — AutomWorx, “Automic Automation V26: Turning Orchestration Into the Control Center for Enterprise AI” (17 September 2026): the article says, “At Automworx, we help teams evaluate, implement, and get real value out of Automic Automation V26, from migration to configuration for a live environment.” The same page describes an “AI Assistant, built on MCP,” AI-assisted scripting and workflow creation, and a model connection that can use a default model in SaaS or a customer-selected LLM for on-premises deployments. This is strong evidence that AutomWorx markets implementation/configuration services for an AI-capable platform. It is not evidence that Meridian uses V26 or has activated these features. [Source](https://www.automworx.com/automic-automation-v26-turning-orchestration-into-the-control-center-for-enterprise-ai/)

Corroborating source — AutomWorx, “Before You Put AI Agents on the Schedule: Start With What Already Runs” (8 October 2026): the article states that an AI agent reaches systems “through service accounts, stored credentials and the connections your jobs already use,” and says AutomWorx consultants build an inventory as part of a “digital ecosystem assessment.” This supports AI-related advisory capability and identifies a relevant access-risk pathway; it does not prove AI agent deployment at Meridian. [Source](https://www.automworx.com/before-you-put-ai-agents-on-the-schedule-start-with-what-already-runs/)

Service/access context — AutomWorx Custom Solutions page: AutomWorx describes custom integrations and says its process includes installing software in non-production and production environments, deployment support, testing, and disaster-recovery configuration. This corroborates that its consulting remit can include production-environment changes; the specific privilege level is supplied by Meridian's workbook. [Source](https://www.automworx.com/consulting-services/custom-solutions/)

Platform corroboration — Broadcom, “Automic V26: Establishing the Intelligent Control Plane for Enterprise AI” (9 April 2026): Broadcom describes Automic V26 model-context-protocol connectivity, model options including Claude, Gemini and OpenAI, self-hosted private models, AI-assisted code generation, generative text-to-workflow, an AI assistant for job-error analysis, and agentic AI jobs subject to RBAC/logging controls. This confirms the platform capability, not

AutomWorx's or Meridian's selected configuration.
[Source](https://automation.broadcom.com/blog/automic-v26-establishing-intelligent-control-plane-enterprise-ai)

Provider-option context — Broadcom, “Automic Automation 24.4 is Here: Unlock the Power of GenAI in Your Automation!” (28 March 2025): for version 24.4, Broadcom lists Gemini, OpenAI GPT, and a local open-source LLM via Ollama; it states Automic SaaS customers use Gemini as the default model for that version. Do not transfer that version-specific statement to Meridian without verifying the installed product/version and hosting model.
[Source](https://automation.broadcom.com/blog/automic-automation-24-4-genai)

Privacy/third-party-sharing review — AutomWorx Privacy Policy (last revision listed as 11 November 2025): the public policy describes sharing information with “trusted partners” for general business support, but does not identify an AI model provider or AI subprocessor in the reviewed text. The absence of a publicly named provider is an **unresolved finding**, not proof that no provider is involved. [Source](https://www.automworx.com/privacy-policy/)

Research limitation: no reviewed public source established that Meridian's current workload-automation deployment is Automic V26, that AI features are enabled, that any Meridian information is sent to a model, or that a particular AI provider processes Meridian information.

How Vendor May Be Using AI

- **Confirmed in the advertised service offering:** AutomWorx publicly offers to evaluate, implement, configure, and support Automic Automation V26, whose documented features include AI-assisted investigation of job outcomes, script assistance/generation, natural-language workflow construction, and agentic AI jobs.
- **AI-agent readiness/advisory:** AutomWorx publishes guidance about cataloguing workload dependencies and assessing which systems and service accounts an AI agent could reach. It advertises a digital ecosystem assessment in that article.
- **Possible operational use if enabled:** AI might summarize execution reports/logs, help diagnose failed jobs, draft or convert scripts, generate workflow definitions, or support agentic jobs that initiate actions. Those are capabilities of the described Automic platform, not confirmed activities in Meridian's deployment.
- **Not established:** whether Meridian uses Automic V26 or another version, whether the AI assistant/MCP/AI jobs are enabled, which data/logs are in scope, what model endpoint is configured, whether any model receives production data, and whether AutomWorx itself uses an AI assistant while performing the contracted service.

Named AI Sub-processors / Model Providers

No AI provider is publicly confirmed as a subcontractor used by AutomWorx for Meridian. Broadcom documents that Automic V26 can connect to public models such as **Anthropic

Claude, Google Gemini, and OpenAI**, or to private/self-hosted models. Broadcom's Automic 24.4 material separately identifies Gemini as that version's Automic SaaS default. These are **platform-supported options**, not evidence that AutomWorx selected any of them or that any provider receives Meridian information. A private/self-hosted deployment may not require an external foundation-model provider for the relevant workload. Confirm the actual provider and endpoint from Meridian's configuration and contract records.

AI Security Risk Classification

MODERATE (provisional)

Risk Rationale

[MODERATE] [HIGH_OPERATIONAL_DEPENDENCY] [PRIVILEGED_ACCESS] [AI_CAPABILITY_CONFIRMED] [MERIDIAN_AI_FLOW_UNVERIFIED] [MODEL_PROVIDER_UNCONFIRMED]

AutomWorx's role reaches the production workload-scheduling layer for core systems, and the supplied inventory states that it can access production schedules, system configuration, and service credentials. Broadcom documents that the Automic V26 platform can expose AI-assisted log/script/workflow functions and agentic AI jobs; if these features were enabled with broad permissions, risks could include unintended production changes, overbroad access via service accounts, disclosure of sensitive scripts/configuration/logs to an external model, and unclear retention or model-training terms. AutomWorx's own AI-agent article recognizes that agent reach can follow existing credentials and connections.

However, the reviewed evidence shows **capability and service offering**, not a confirmed Meridian implementation. The workbook states there is no direct customer-data access, and public OSINT does not establish an AI-to-Meridian data flow, selected model provider, or enabled agentic runtime. Moderate is therefore a calibrated provisional rating rather than a finding of actual exposure. Upgrade to **High** if Meridian's internal evidence confirms AI features can access production credentials, sensitive execution artefacts, or job-execution rights; consider **Critical** only if there is unrestricted autonomous production action combined with major control gaps and high business impact.

Recommended Action

1. **Confirm deployment and feature status internally.** Use Meridian's system owner, installed-version records, change tickets, configuration exports, and current contracts to identify the scheduler product/version and whether AI Assistant, MCP/AI connections, AI jobs, `ASK_AI` functions, or equivalent features are enabled. Do not infer enablement from marketing material and do not contact the vendor.
2. **Map the AI access boundary.** Identify which job definitions, scripts, execution reports, logs, configuration files, and service accounts any AI component can read or use. Check

whether logs or prompts could contain account information, tokens, passwords, keys, or other secrets even though the inventory says there is no direct customer-data access.
3. **Verify model routing and terms.** From internal configuration and contract material, record the actual model/provider, endpoint, SaaS versus self-hosted arrangement, processing region, retention, telemetry, model-training terms, and any onward provider. If the provider cannot be identified, record it as unresolved rather than assuming one from product documentation.
4. **Limit production authority.** Apply least-privilege and scoped service accounts; keep secrets in a managed vault; redact secrets from prompts/logs; separate diagnostic AI from execution privileges; and require approval before AI-originated changes or production jobs that can cause material or hard-to-reverse effects.
5. **Require observability and safe disablement.** Ensure prompts/requests and AI-originated recommendations/actions are logged, generated scripts and workflows are validated and tested outside production, outputs are checked before execution, and Meridian can disable the AI integration without disabling the underlying deterministic scheduling function.
6. **Reassess when confirmed.** If AI is disabled or isolated from production data/credentials, retain the evidence and monitor changes during upgrades. If enabled with production access, elevate the AI security risk to High until provider, data flow, permissions, human approval, and audit controls are validated.

Assessed By / Date

[Enter team name] / 12 October 2026

3. Criticality assessment — deeper dimensions

This breakdown makes the **High** criticality decision repeatable. Ratings below are analyst judgments from the supplied profile; “unverified” means the workbook/public sources do not supply enough detail to treat the point as fact.

- **Business-function centrality — HIGH.** The supported process is batch scheduling across core systems, not an administrative or peripheral function.
- **System-of-record / process authority — MODERATE to HIGH.** The workload scheduler orchestrates jobs and configurations; no source says AutomWorx itself is the system of record for customer accounts or transaction records.
- **Failure blast radius — HIGH (potential).** A scheduler or configuration failure may affect multiple core-system jobs. The exact dependency map and number of downstream applications are not provided.
- **Time criticality — HIGH (provisional).** Batch jobs are scheduled and may support deadline-driven processes; Meridian-specific run windows, SLAs, and cut-off times are not supplied.
- **Workaround availability — UNVERIFIED / provisional MEDIUM.** No evidence says whether Meridian staff or an alternative provider can take over production job operations promptly.
- **Recoverability — UNVERIFIED / provisional MEDIUM.** No Meridian-specific RTO/RPO, backup, rollback, or recovery-test evidence was supplied.

- **Transaction integrity — MODERATE to HIGH (conditional).** Incorrect job definitions, duplicated/replayed jobs, or out-of-order execution could affect downstream processing if those jobs handle consequential transactions. The actual job catalogue is not provided.
- **Data consequence — MODERATE.** No direct customer data is listed; however, production configuration, schedules, scripts, and service credentials are security-sensitive and may provide indirect reach into other systems.
- **Exit / substitutability — MEDIUM (provisional).** Automic/UC4/AppWorx skills are specialized, but there is no evidence about exclusivity, contract exit terms, internal skills, or alternate support.
- **Regulatory / compliance criticality — MEDIUM (provisional).** Core-system batch jobs may underpin reporting, reconciliation, or compliance processes, but the supplied record does not identify particular regulated jobs.
- **Financial materiality — HIGH (potential).** A delay or unauthorized change across core-system scheduling can have consequential downstream effects; the actual financial exposure has not been quantified.
- **Concentration / dependency risk — HIGH for operational dependency; exclusivity unverified.** The workbook explicitly assigns High dependency, but does not establish that AutomWorx is Meridian's only support option.

Overall rating logic: High operational dependency + core-system batch scheduling + privileged production configuration/credentials = **HIGH**. The lack of direct customer-data access and the absence of evidence on exclusivity, recovery, or unrestricted production control prevent an evidence-based Critical rating at this stage.

4. Evidence strength and interpretation rules

- **High confidence — what the vendor publicly offers:** AutomWorx's service pages and V26 article are first-party sources for its advertised consulting scope and the platform capabilities it supports.
- **High confidence — platform capability:** Broadcom's official material supports the existence of Automic AI/LLM features and names supported model options.
- **Not established — live Meridian configuration:** No reviewed source identifies Meridian's installed version, AI feature flags, model endpoint, prompt contents, or data egress.
- **Not established — provider/subprocessor relationship:** A model being technically supported by Automic is not proof of a contract or data-processing relationship with AutomWorx or Meridian.
- **Not established — direct customer-data exposure:** The workbook explicitly says no direct customer data. Do not relabel that as AI data exposure without separate evidence. Still review logs and configuration because these can be sensitive and may contain secrets or indirect customer references.

5. Source register

All sources below were reviewed on **12 October 2026**. Product capability pages are used to describe possible functionality, not to assert that Meridian has enabled it.

1. **AutomWorx — Automic Automation V26 article (17 Sep 2026).** AI feature description and statement that AutomWorx helps customers implement/configure V26 for live environments.

https://www.automworx.com/automic-automation-v26-turning-orchestration-into-the-control-center-for-enterprise-ai/
2. **AutomWorx — Before You Put AI Agents on the Schedule (8 Oct 2026).** AI-agent access path through service accounts/credentials; digital ecosystem assessment offering.

https://www.automworx.com/before-you-put-ai-agents-on-the-schedule-start-with-what-already-runs/
3. **AutomWorx — Workload Automation Consulting Services.** Implementations, upgrades, migrations, support and education for Automic/AppWorx/UC4.
   https://www.automworx.com/consulting-services/
4. **AutomWorx — Custom Solutions.** Custom integrations, production/non-production installation, deployment support and disaster recovery configuration.
   https://www.automworx.com/consulting-services/custom-solutions/
5. **Broadcom — Automic V26: Establishing the Intelligent Control Plane for Enterprise AI (9 Apr 2026).** MCP/BYOM, Claude/Gemini/OpenAI/private models, AI jobs, code assistance and workflow generation.

https://automation.broadcom.com/blog/automic-v26-establishing-intelligent-control-plane-enterprise-ai
6. **Broadcom — Automic Automation 24.4 GenAI article (28 Mar 2025).** Gemini/OpenAI GPT/Ollama options; Gemini SaaS default stated for version 24.4 only.
   https://automation.broadcom.com/blog/automic-automation-24-4-genai
7. **AutomWorx — Privacy Policy (last revision listed as 11 Nov 2025).** Generic trusted-partner sharing language; no AI provider named in the reviewed policy text.
   https://www.automworx.com/privacy-policy/

Final decision to carry into the workbook

- **Criticality Tier:** High
- **Assessment Depth Applied:** Deep / High-tier review
- **AI Usage Detected:** Yes — AI-enabled service offering confirmed; Meridian enablement unverified
- **Named AI Sub-processors / Model Providers:** None confirmed for AutomWorx/Meridian; Claude, Gemini and OpenAI are platform-supported model options documented by Broadcom, not confirmed recipients of Meridian data
- **AI Security Risk Classification:** Moderate (provisional; elevate to High if AI features have production access)